Department of Political Science

Seeing Corruption: Digital Information Environments and Corruption Perceptions in Kenya

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Abstract

How does social media use affect perceived corruption in Kenya? What people think about corruption matters for functioning institutions and democratic accountability. The information environment is a significant driver of these perceptions but has undergone dramatic change over the past two decades. In particular, features of social media – reliance on user-generated content, network-based diffusion, and algorithmic curation – shape how information spreads on digital platforms and impact individual corruption perceptions. Using *Afrobarometer* and *Machine Learning for Peace* data, I examine the development of corruption perceptions among social media users in Kenya during times of high and low corruption salience. I find that social media users in Kenya perceive higher corruption than non-users. In times of high corruption salience, Kenyans perceive corruption trends to improve rather than worsen, lending support to an accountability signal interpretation. Future research should further examine the divergence between corruption-level and corruption-trend measurements and exploit individual-level variation of corruption information exposure.

Keywords: corruption perceptions; social media; information environment; media effects; Kenya; Afrobarometer.

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1 Introduction

> "Corruption is the root wound that makes every other crisis worse. Corruption directly steals from hospitals, schools, roads and food security. Young people are angry because they see billions being looted while graduates sell sweets on the streets and patients die in public hospitals."
>
> *Hanifa Adan Safia, Kenyan Gen Z protester, quoted in Ahmed (2025).*

Initially sparked by the rejection of the 2024 Finance Bill, the June 2024 Kenya Gen Z protests evolved into an unprecedented, social media-driven nationwide movement demanding broad systemic reforms and accountability for corruption in government (Ingutia, 2025). While national issues were at the forefront, countrywide protests were paralleled by local demonstrations focusing on the alleged corruption and broken promises of county-level politicians who "arrogantly display wealth that cannot come from official salaries and reasonable expenses alone" (Lynch, 2024, p. 2).

The popular outrage witnessed in Kenya is a modern manifestation of a much older problem. Corruption is a deeply rooted, complex, and multi-dimensional phenomenon that is often embedded in a society's political institutions and cultural norms (Damijan, 2023; Rose-Ackerman & Palifka, 2016). It replaces rule-bound impartial decision-making with willingness to pay and thereby distorts the allocation of public resources, widens inequality, and erodes trust (Dincer et al., 2025; Gründler & Potrafke, 2019; Rothstein, 2011). Understanding the conditions and institutions that help reduce corruption is therefore high on the agenda of political science.

An effective response to corruption hinges on perceptions of corruption. This is especially important in democracies, where voters are expected to sanction corrupt behavior in elections (Ashworth, 2012; Vries & Solaz, 2017). However, in what has been called a "fundamental puzzle" (Bøttkjær & Justesen, 2021, p. 788) of political science, voters across many contexts continue to (re-)elect corrupt politicians (e.g., Chang et al., 2010; Jones, 1999; Klašnja, 2017). While information is not the only factor shaping electoral sanctioning, it is a necessary first step toward electoral accountability. The beliefs citizens hold about corruption shape the institutions they support and the way they engage with them (Rothstein, 2011). The information environment in which those beliefs are formed is therefore consequential not only for electoral accountability but for institutional health more broadly.

Because political corruption is typically concealed by those engaging in it, citizens depend on media outlets to learn about it – and that media environment has changed fundamentally in the past 20 years. The global media environment is characterized by an accelerating shift from traditional outlets toward a fragmented, video-led ecosystem of social platforms and alternative creators, placing unprecedented pressure on established journalistic business models (Reuters Institute, 2025). This new information environment of social media – which is characterized by low barriers to entry, networks, and algorithmic content distribution (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025; Zhuravskaya et al., 2020) – changes the logic of content distribution, reshaping what information becomes prominent. The most prominent articles on the role of information on corruption voting, however, were written during the era of legacy media, often focusing on information distribution via print media (Chang et al., 2010; Costas-Pérez et al., 2012), radio stations (Ferraz & Finan, 2008), or leaflet campaigns (Adida et al., 2020; Arias et al., 2019; Chong et al., 2015).

How does social media news consumption shape attitudes towards corruption? To answer this question, the thesis examines whether variation in digital media exposure is associated with differences in perceived corruption, whether users respond more strongly than non-users to changes in the broader news environment, and whether these effects strengthen over time. In doing so, it concentrates on corruption perception as the first stage in the broader process of corruption voting. Empirically, this thesis combines Afrobarometer survey data from Kenya with media salience data from the Machine Learning for Peace project by Moratz et al. (2025) to examine whether exposure to digital information environments is associated with higher corruption perceptions over time.

Three findings emerge. First, Kenyans who regularly use social media for news consistently perceive higher corruption than non-users, though the effect is small. Second, in periods of high corruption news salience, Kenyans report that corruption is improving rather than worsening – a counterintuitive pattern consistent with an accountability-signal interpretation, in which intensified reporting is read as evidence of institutional response rather than failure. Third, neither the responsiveness of users to changes in the news environment nor the temporal evolution of the social media effect finds support in the data. Together, these results suggest that social media functions as one source of corruption information among many in Kenya rather than a uniquely powerful channel.

The contribution of this thesis is threefold. Theoretically, the thesis brings together insights from the electoral accountability and corruption-voting literatures with broader research on the political effects of digital media. This is timely as online platforms shift toward *post-social* media governed by recommendation-based algorithms (Törnberg & Rogers, 2026), evaluating how the previous information revolution shaped corruption perceptions becomes especially important. Substantively, the thesis adds to a small but growing literature on the role of social media in shaping electoral accountability and corruption perceptions. The thesis thereby updates and re-evaluates whether seminal findings – such as those by Ferraz and Finan (2008) regarding the power of radio-based information to increase the electoral costs of corruption – extend to the digital age. It does so in the context of Sub-Saharan Africa, where legacy media have often been weak or captured. In these contexts, digital media may produce accountability effects that differ significantly from those documented in Western democracies, which have traditionally been the primary focus of scholarly attention (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025). Methodologically, this thesis adopts a focused analytical strategy by isolating corruption perceptions as the first step towards electoral accountability (Vries & Solaz, 2017). By narrowing the focus to this first step, the study minimizes the "noise" from downstream factors like blame attribution or strategic voting, thereby providing a cleaner estimation of the informational effect of social media. New and more granular corruption news salience data (Moratz et al., 2025) further enables a direct test of whether social media users are more responsive to the broader news environment than non-users.

The remainder of the thesis proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews how the information environment shapes corruption perceptions and sets out why social media differs from legacy media as an informational channel. Section 3 develops the theoretical framework and derives the hypotheses around three expectations: Direct exposure to corruption content, responsiveness to the wider news environment, and the maturation of the social media channel over time. Section 4 motivates Kenya as a case, and section 5 describes the data, variables, and identification strategy. Section 6 presents the results, which section 7 then interprets and evaluates against previous research and limitations.

2 Corruption Perceptions and the New Information Environment

2.1 Corruption and Government

The consensus definition of corruption is the abuse of entrusted power for private gain. The harm is twofold, first, corrupt officials may act contrary to their mandate; second, even when they do something that would otherwise be permissible, they effectively sell a decision or access that should be allocated by rules rather than by willingness to pay (Rose-Ackerman & Palifka, 2016). Corruption thereby distorts the allocation of public resources, widens inequality, and erodes trust (Dincer et al., 2025; Gründler & Potrafke, 2019).

By replacing rule-bound decision-making with particularistic allocation, corruption is corrosive to predictable institutions (Acemoglu & Robinson, 2008). Rothstein (2011) describes a self-reinforcing "Low Trust–Corruption–Inequality Trap", in which experiencing corruption reduces trust not only in public authorities but in people generally, making fair implementation of policy harder (see also Seligson, 2002). In this light, understanding how citizens perceive corruption – and what information feeds those perceptions – becomes central to understanding its political consequences. Democratic institutions are meant to check corruption primarily through electoral accountability: Voters periodically reward or sanction politicians for their conduct in office (Ferejohn, 1986). For this mechanism to bite on corruption specifically, voters must not only observe wrongdoing but also attribute it to the correct official and weigh it against competing considerations at the ballot box (Ashworth, 2012; Powell & Whitten, 1993).

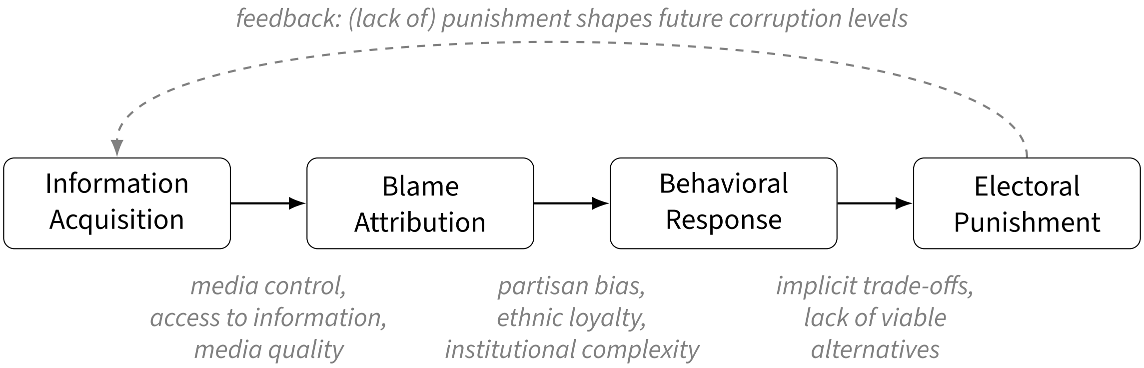


Figure 1: *Feedback Loop for Electoral Accountability of Corruption.* The three steps follow Vries and Solaz (2017).

Vries and Solaz (2017) formalize this as a sequential chain. Voters must first acquire information about corrupt behavior, then attribute responsibility, and finally prioritize integrity over other electoral considerations. Figure 1 depicts the framework. Each step is a necessary but not sufficient condition for the next, and a breakdown at any point prevents electoral sanctioning. This thesis isolates the first link – information acquisition and perception formation – as the analytically cleaner object of study, and returns to the societal implications in the discussion.

2.2 How Information Shapes Corruption Perceptions

This section examines what prior research has understood about the conditions under which information about corruption does and does not lead to an update in corruption perceptions and how certain we can be of what we know so far. Much of this literature is grounded in corruption voting, but I focus on the elements that engage with arguments on corruption perceptions.

For information on corruption to have an effect on perceptions, information must be accessible. This is a non-trivial condition because "politicians go to substantial lengths to conceal their corrupt activities." (Vries & Solaz, 2017, p. 396) Visibility of political corruption is therefore contingent on public information and media availability. Ferraz and Finan (2008)'s influential study is a prominent case for the effects of providing information. Exploiting a natural experiment of a lottery design of municipal audit assignments, they examine the results of audit reports on mayors' re-election rates across Brazil. Their results show that corrupt mayors who were audited just before an election lose vote share compared to non-corrupt candidates as well as to corrupt candidates audited after an election. This effect is significantly stronger in areas covered by a local radio station. The two main takeaways from the study are that (1) people are responsive to corruption information, and (2), updating corruption beliefs in response to information relies on media reporting. Local media availability is particularly important in this context (Larreguy et al., 2020).

The salience of corruption in the media environment at large further affects corruption perceptions. In particular, corruption needs to become a prominent issue for voters to change their beliefs and take action in voting (Costas-Pérez et al., 2012) or protest participation (Gingerich, 2009). A good example is the "Clean Hands period" in Italy. Being charged with a crime did not significantly hurt a deputy's re-election chances through much of post-war Italy's parliamentary history but during a period from 1992-1994, which came along with massive media coverage of corruption, charges of serious malfeasance were strongly negatively associated with re-election. This effect was particularly strong in districts with high per capita circulation of newspapers and magazines (Chang et al., 2010). These findings indicate that a potential "threshold" effect of corruption information prominence unlocks relatively sudden changes in corruption perceptions. The role of local networks to reach an audience beyond the immediate consumers of an information medium as well as to coordinate collective action plays an important role here (Adida et al., 2020; Arias et al., 2019).

Corruption information must further be perceived as credible. Whereby accusations from political figures are often discounted as biased, accusations coming from a trusted third party are given more value (Rundquist et al., 1977). Highly trusted sources, like the results of independent audits, are therefore shown to often lead to a change in perceived corruption across the literature (e.g., Arias et al., 2022; Ferraz & Finan, 2008; Mbithi & Kijima, 2026)[1]. Other sources of information receive less trust and have lower chances of changing corruption perceptions, respectively. In this context, Klaveren et al. (2024) find that social media – and especially posts from anonymous sources – are given considerably less credibility than more traditional sources of information, such as newspapers. Interest groups play a role as well, as they can deliberately delegitimize otherwise credible information to shape perceptions in their favor (Berry & Howell, 2007).

Furthermore, the way new information affects voters must be understood in the context of prior beliefs. If corruption is perceived ubiqutous, even objectively bad news can be interpreted as relatively good news (Arias et al., 2022). Similarly, the perceptions of a candidate's anti-corruption stance affect how new information about corruption is perceived. Voters are more likely to punish a corrupt candidate when that candidate's supporters belong to a party with a stronger anti-corruption reputation, whereas equivalent corruption information had little effect among supporters for whom corruption was less central to vote choice (de Figueiredo et al., 2023).

On a methodological note, some of the findings might overemphasize the actual effect of information on corruption perceptions. The use of experimental methods to identify is widespread which allows higher internal validity of the identification of the treatment effect. However, experiments often differ substantially from the information people encounter in every day life, where corruption allegations are typically "vague, diffuse in who it accuses of wrongdoing, disseminated by partisan sources, and not accessible in the period immediately

[1] This is also due to the research designs that can be connected to plausible exogeneity in their release time.

before elections." (Winters & Weitz-Shapiro, 2013, p. 430) Considering the number of studies employing survey experiments[2], this raises broader concerns about external validity. Incerti (2020, p. 761) shows in a meta-analysis that corrupt candidates are punished by essentially zero percentage points in field experiments, but by roughly 32 percentage points in survey experiments. This suggests that the existing literature may overstate the effects of corruption information when relying on highly salient, credible, and temporally concentrated treatments that differ from real-world conditions. Similarly, publication bias might further amplify this problem. Dunning et al. (2019)'s preregistered meta-analysis of coordinated trials across six countries finds largely null effects and suggests research may have overstated the impact of corruption-related information campaigns.

Taken together, the literature points to a central implication: Information about corruption *does* lead to higher corruption perceptions. However, this process is contingent on whether information is accessible, salient, and credible and must be understood in the context of individual prior beliefs. It is also not the case that information is the only attribute that affects corruption perceptions. Peoples' beliefs are constructs of a complex interplay of different factors and their beliefs are not a monolithic function of (a lack of) information. Furthermore, corruption perceptions do not necessarily have consequences and they are only the first step in a series of steps towards concrete action, like voting or protest participation.

2.3 Why Social Media is Different

The insight that the information environment shapes perceptions is reflected in studies examining the effects of newspapers (Costas-Pérez et al., 2012), magazines (Chang et al., 2010), and radio stations (Ferraz & Finan, 2008) on corruption perceptions and voting. The media environment, however, has changed substantially since the rise of the internet and social networks (for reviews see Farrell, 2012; Zhuravskaya et al., 2020). In Europe, between 35 and 67% of citizens report using social media for news while print use has fallen dramatically. The shift has been even sharper in the Global South; internet and social media use – primarily mobile-based – is rapidly rising and Kenya has become the country with the highest usage of TikTok for news. Younger generations everywhere consume news via social media more than older generations, suggesting this trend is only accelerating (Reuters Institute, 2025).

Social media could have similar effects to legacy media when it comes to affecting perceptions of corruption. However, there are defining differences between legacy and social media that drive how information is disseminated and consumed (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025). The three key features are lower barriers to entry, network effects, and algorithmic content distribution.

[2]From the articles discussed here, e.g., Bøttkjær and Justesen (2021), de Figueiredo et al. (2023), Elia and Schwindt-Bayer (2022), Klaveren et al. (2024), and Winters and Weitz-Shapiro (2013), 2016, use survey experiments.

First, barriers to entry are lower and reliance on user-generated content is a cornerstone of social media. While traditional media required substantial capital and physical infrastructure – making it highly susceptible to capture by elected officials (see, e.g., Guriev, 2022) – the digital environment of the 2020s requires little more than a smartphone and a data connection to spread news "en masse" (Enríquez et al., 2024a). In other words, the diversity of viewpoints that can potentially engage in the public discourse at low costs has risen, while the opportunities for influence by state actors have initially reduced (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025).

Lower barriers to entry potentially mean more information available – and therefore more corruption information – but also undermine traditional reputation mechanisms that can ensure quality of information (Zhuravskaya et al., 2020). Importantly, declining reliance on traditional media such as newspapers or radio may also weaken the supply of "accountability-enhancing content" (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025, p. 418) they produce (see also Balles et al., 2026). At the same time, the lower barriers to facilitate the creation and spread of misinformation (Vosoughi et al., 2018). There is also a risk of crowding-out important information due to high levels of media noise (Balles et al., 2026).

Second, social media is not a one-way street but allows instantaneous feedback and the creation of networks. The architecture of horizontal, two-way communication allows users not only to consume but also to selectively curate, amplify, and reshare content (Zhuravskaya et al., 2020). The decentralized nature of social media also fragments the information environment: Rather than encountering counterattitudinal information, users are channelled into echo chambers and filter bubbles that reinforce existing beliefs (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025). Using digital trace data from more than 160,000 public TikTok accounts in the US, Li et al. (2025) find that "clusters of politically homogeneous networks" expose users to attitude-consistent political content, and that users with stronger political views and more positive social feedback are more likely to express political opinions – suggesting that platform dynamics reinforce ideological segregation rather than expose users to opposing viewpoints. Vosoughi et al. (2018) document a parallel logic of networked amplification: Falsehood on Twitter diffuses "farther, faster, deeper, and more broadly than the truth" (p. 2) because users actively reshare emotionally charged content through their networks.

Third, and building on the previous points, the logic of algorithmic content distribution on profit-driven platforms reshapes which information becomes salient. While the field of algorithm studies is just emerging in the social sciences, the way in which social media algorithms shape content creation and distribution is essential to understand the effects of social media in the 2020s. Recommendation systems are optimized to maximize attention (click-through, watch time, reshares), not informational quality or civic value (Balles et al., 2026; Nyabola, 2018). In the words of van der Nagel (2018, p. 84): "The algorithms used by these platforms may not be clear, but the goal of any platform is easy to understand, as it is rooted in neoliberal systems of profit." As a result, feeds systematically privilege content with high predicted engagement and often content that is sensational, affect-laden, or ideologically proximate over factual reporting (Li et al., 2025; Zhuravskaya et al., 2020) and further promote ideologically aligned content (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025). The findings from Vosoughi et al. (2018, p. 4-5) add to this picture: "false rumors inspired replies expressing greater surprise" and were more likely to elicit emotions of "novelty" and "disgust" than true news, creating more engagement and thereby profit for platform operators. While temporal and platform variation exists, the general pattern holds up across platforms (Balles et al., 2026).

2.4 Social Media and Corruption Perceptions

Taken together, these features suggest that social media does not merely change the medium or increase the quantity of available political information, but changes the conditions under which corruption information becomes visible, credible, and salient – the factors discussed above that shape whether information becomes a driver for changing attitudes.

On a macro level, the expansion of the internet has reinforced the assumption that more information leads to higher corruption perceptions. Guriev et al. (2021) find that the expansion of mobile coverage between 2008–2017 led to a significant decrease in confidence in government and an increase in corruption perceptions across the globe – contingent on internet censorship, control of traditional media, and levels of actual corruption. They interpret this as evidence that uncensored mobile broadband helps expose misgovernance, making it a tool for political accountability. This effect is stronger in societies where the main grievances are related to "corruption, subversion of power, and control of traditional media" (Zhuravskaya et al., 2020, p. 433).

Which features of social media exactly drive this relationship remains a topic of discussion. Virality mechanisms – that is the observation that most posts will vanish after a short time, but a few will explode, leading to very high amounts of attention across broad recipients – are expected to play a role in the creation of widely shared beliefs (Enríquez et al., 2024a). The strong interactive potential of social media and the potential for the "creation of supportive networks for anticorruption movements" (Pasolo & Pasolo, 2025, p. 353) further amplify social media's role in driving corruption perceptions. How specific cultural themes and trends from online communities interact with the prevalence and spread of individual corruption stories remains an interesting avenue for further research[3]. On a *micro level*, social media has a significant impact on attitudes towards corruption. The emotionally engaging and often personalized narratives of social media often outperform more fact-heavy documentary-style content (Denisova-Schmidt et al., 2019). However, lower levels of trust often relayed to social media sources could negatively impact the effect of corruption allegations online (Klaveren et al., 2024).

[3]In a "netnographic" study (combination of *net* and *ethnographic*), Pasolo and Pasolo (2025) examine the prevalence of anti-corruption themes on TikTok during Indonesia's presidential election. Their findings show that comments that were themed towards viral trends or other online communities were outperforming others.

In general, the effect of social media on information acquisition constitutes an avenue for increased research. Compared to traditional media systems, social media algorithms increasingly decide what people get to see and the role of gatekeepers, such as journalists, editors, or publishers, has decreased dramatically (Nyabola, 2018; Törnberg & Rogers, 2026). This has implications for the study of corruption, as the exposure to information about corruption – and to political information in general – shapes attitudes and voting behavior.

3 Theoretical Framework and Hypotheses

This thesis isolates the first step in the Vries and Solaz (2017) chain: How citizens come to perceive corruption. Sanctioning elected representatives depends on attribution and ballot-box behaviour, but neither is possible without information first reaching voters (see figure 1). Focusing on perception formation also offers a cleaner empirical target than the full chain, since it sets aside downstream noise from partisanship, blame attribution, and strategic voting (Incerti, 2020).

The question this section develops is whether, and how, social media shapes that first step given its distinctive informational architecture (section 2.3). The argument is additive rather than substitutive. Social media is a new channel layered onto Kenya's existing media environment, not a replacement for it, and the empirical task is to determine its marginal contribution to perception formation. Three features of the digital environment motivate the hypotheses that follow: Lower barriers to entry combined with user-generated content, networked diffusion of politically salient material, and algorithmic content distribution that systematically privileges high-engagement content (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025; Zhuravskaya et al., 2020). Each feature influences perception formation in a different way, and each generates a testable expectation around direct exposure, responsiveness to the wider news environment, and the temporal evolution of the social media channel itself.

The most immediate implication of social media's architecture is that users encounter more political content than non-users, and a non-trivial share of that content concerns corruption. Lower barriers to entry mean that journalists, activists, and ordinary citizens can all surface allegations of malfeasance, and networked diffusion ensures that this content circulates beyond its original audience (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025). The legacy-media literature establishes that exposure to credible information shifts perceptions of corruption (Chang et al., 2010; Costas-Pérez et al., 2012; Ferraz & Finan, 2008), and the digital extension is consistent with this logic. Guriev et al. (2021) show that the subnational expansion of mobile broadband raises perceived corruption, and Denisova-Schmidt et al. (2019) document that short-form social-media exposure can shift anti-corruption attitudes among Ukrainian students. These mechanisms imply a basic exposure effect at the individual level; those who use social media for news should, on average, perceive corruption as more widespread than those who do not.

Effects of social media on corruption voting may be distinct in new and low-income democracies because these platforms interact with different preexisting media and institutional environments (Nyabola, 2018). On the one hand, where traditional media are captured or inaccessible, social media may more strongly expand pluralism, reduce information costs, and give voice to actors who can expose corruption. On the other hand, where corrective information and institutional safeguards are weaker, the same platforms may also more easily amplify misinformation, unequal visibility, and manipulation (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025).

Three factors temper expectations about the magnitude of this effect. First, social media operates alongside a relatively active legacy-media environment in Kenya (Freedom House, 2025), so the marginal contribution beyond radio, television, and newspapers may be modest. Second, citizens assign lower credibility to content sourced from social media than from traditional outlets (Klaveren et al., 2024), which dampens individual updating per item encountered. Third, information bubbles could lead to information that does not fit one's world view reaching individuals. The hypothesis is therefore directional: Social media should add to perceived corruption but is not the only determinant.

$\mathbf{H}_{\textbf{Information}}$: Individuals who use social media for news consumption are more likely to perceive corruption as widespread than individuals who do not.

This exposure logic extends naturally to a second prediction. If social media lowers the costs of accessing and circulating political content, then users should also be more responsive to changes in the wider information environment. When corruption coverage rises across the media landscape, citizens in general should encounter it more often and update their perceptions accordingly. Among social media users, this updating should be amplified, since networked and algorithmic diffusion ensures that high-salience content travels further and faster within their feeds than among non-users who rely on legacy outlets alone (Larreguy & Raffler, 2025; Zhuravskaya et al., 2020). Guriev et al. (2021) formalize this intuition at the regional level when they argue that "incidents of corruption should translate into higher perceptions of corruption in subnational regions with greater access to mobile broadband internet" (p. 2585). The argument here translates this responsiveness logic to the individual level by interacting national-level corruption news salience with individual social media use.

A note on the directional content of the baseline expectation is in order, because the literature is more ambiguous than a simple "more coverage, more perceived corruption" reading suggests. The dominant prediction in the accountability literature is that higher corruption coverage produces higher perceived corruption, on the logic that voters update on revealed wrongdoing (Chang et al., 2010; Ferraz & Finan, 2008). The same uptick in coverage could, however, carry a different signal in a high-corruption baseline environment such as Kenya's. Arias et al. (2022) show in a Mexican field experiment that voters update in a Bayesian way. When prior expectations of politicians are already very low, even objectively bad news can be read as relatively good news, because it signals institutional capacity to expose wrongdoing rather than the wrongdoing itself. This alternative reading is plausible, and I return to it in the discussion. The weight of evidence, however, points the other way; across a wide range of settings, citizens do react to corruption information by revising their perceptions upward (Chang et al., 2010; Costas-Pérez et al., 2012; Ferraz & Finan, 2008; Guriev et al., 2021). I therefore expect higher corruption news salience to be associated with higher perceived corruption, as encoded in the hypothesis below.

> $\mathbf{H}_{\mathbf{Baseline}}$: Higher salience of corruption-related news coverage is associated with higher corruption perceptions.

> $\mathbf{H}_{\mathbf{Responsiveness}}$: The association between corruption news salience and corruption perceptions is stronger among social media users than among non-users.

A final consideration concerns time as social media is not a stable treatment across the period studied. Between 2014 and 2024, both penetration and platform architecture changed substantially in Kenya and globally. The number of Kenyans reporting social media as a news source rose from a low base in round 6 to a clear majority in round 10, and the platforms themselves evolved from text-and-image feeds anchored in social graphs towards short-form video governed by interest-based recommendation. Törnberg and Rogers (2026) argues that this represents a deeper paradigm shift: The active "user" of the early social media era is being repositioned as a more passive "viewer" of algorithmically curated content, and an increasing share of what citizens see is selected by recommendation systems rather than peer networks. Earlier work on legacy media points in a similar direction, showing that media environments can change and become more consequential as they mature and producers adapt to new technologies (Gentzkow et al., 2006). If these dynamics make social media a progressively more efficient channel for surfacing corruption-related content, the gap in perceptions between users and non-users should widen across rounds.

> $\mathbf{H}_{\mathbf{Maturation}}$: The difference in corruption perceptions between social media users and non-users increases over time as the social media environment matures.

4 The Case of Kenya

Kenya is a likely case for social media to shape corruption perceptions as Kenya combines an advanced digital information environment with persistently high corruption. If a social media effect is detectable anywhere in Sub-Saharan Africa, Kenya is among the most probable places to find it. The choice rests on three grounds specifically.

First, Kenya is one of the most digitally advanced countries in Sub-Saharan Africa. The Kenyan government has made many public services available online through its eCitizen platform, is home to the highly successful mobile phone-based money transfer service M-Pesa, and is known for a vibrant digital public sphere, for example, under the hashtag #KOT ("Kenyans on Twitter"). Nairobi has also been dubbed the Silicon Savannah for its booming technology and innovation ecosystem (Nyabola, 2018). Kenya also has one of the highest use rates of social media for news consumption and is the democracy with the highest share of news consumption via TikTok (Reuters Institute, 2025).

Second, Kenya remains plagued by relatively high levels of corruption. It ranks as the 60th most corrupt country (Transparency International, 2024) and corruption is pervasive in politics, the judiciary, as well as the police (Freedom House, 2025). The relevance of corruption is further highlighted by the recent Gen Z-led protests that began in 2024, in which opposition to the finance bill became closely intertwined with broader criticism of corruption, misgovernance, and political unaccountability (Ahmed, 2025).

Finally, Kenya is a place of relative stability within the region and is seen as a comparatively well-functioning democracy in East Africa. It is classified as an electoral democracy according to the latest V-Dem report (Nord et al., 2026) and the presidency has seen regular transfers of power since the end of President Daniel arap Moi's rule in 2002. A constitutional reform in 2010 has been widely regarded as a milestone in Kenya's history, reducing the power of the executive, devolving authority to county governments, and expanding social and economic rights for women, minorities, and marginalized communities (Kramon & Posner, 2011). However, the country has also seen severe election-related violence, most notably in 2007-08 and again in 2017 (Nyabola, 2018).

5 Methodology

5.1 Data, Variables, and Descriptive Statistics

Individual-level data on corruption perceptions, social media (SM in the following) use, and control variables are drawn from rounds 6–10 of the Afrobarometer survey in Kenya between November 2014 and May 2024. Afrobarometer provides nationally representative survey data on adult citizens and includes repeated questions on perceived corruption as well as media and technology use[4]. $\sim$2,400 respondents are interviewed face-to-face per survey round (see table A1 in the appendix for more details on dates and respondent numbers) and are stratified by sub-national unit of government and urban/rural location. The interviewees alternate by gender and interviews are held in the respondent's preferred language.

[4] I use these specific survey rounds, as the main independent variable that is introduced below, SM news use, is only included from round 6 onwards and the corruption news salience data does not cover the entire period of round 5. See appendix table A2.

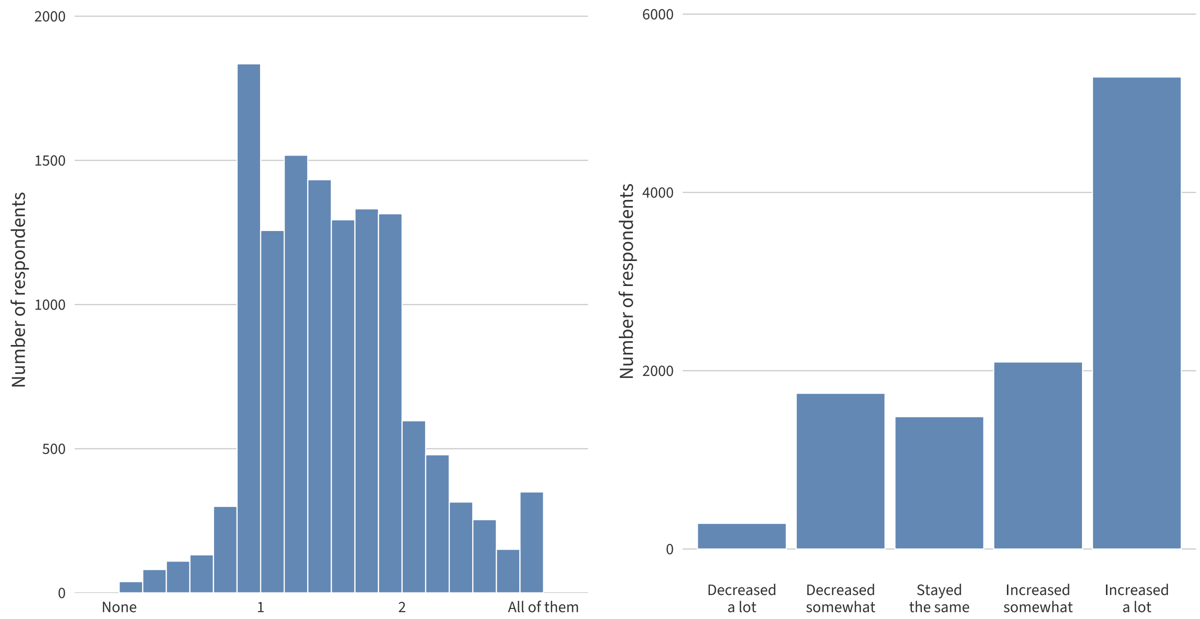
Corruption Perceptions

The main dependent variable of the analysis is corruption perceptions which I measure using an index and a trend variable. While corruption perceptions may deviate from more objective measures of corruption, they are ultimately the precondition for individual behavior like electoral support or protest mobilization and affect the institutional environment in general (see section 2.1). The main corruption question battery used throughout all iterations of the survey is "How many of the following people do you think are involved in corruption, or haven't you heard enough about them to say:" followed by a list of national and regional elected representatives (e.g., the President, MPs, local government county assembly members), as well as unelected public servants (e.g., the police, business executives, religious leaders)[5]. Respondents can answer on a four point scale where 0 indicates "none" and 3 indicates "all of them". The structure of this question battery mirrors operationalizations commonly used across public opinion surveys and the broader literature (e.g., Bouraïma et al., 2025; Sun & Payne, 2022), however, this approach is associated with potential risks. First, the perception of corruption for questions targeting politicians (e.g., the president or an MP) could be affected by characteristics of the specific person. These individual characteristics of elected representatives could affect how respondents evaluate corruption, for example discounting corruption for politicians with a shared party affiliation (e.g., Agerberg, 2020; Elia & Schwindt-Bayer, 2022) or ethnicity (e.g., Horowitz & Long, 2016). Second, while this study focuses on the effects of indirect exposure to corruption through media and information environments, some items in the battery are more likely than others to reflect direct personal experience. This applies especially to citizen-facing actors such as the police, but also potentially to local officials or tax authorities, with whom respondents may encounter corruption in everyday interactions.

To address these concerns, I construct a corruption perception index from the subset of items that appear in every survey wave and that capture perceptions of corruption among public actors[6]. The use of a combined index reduces the risk of responses being driven by sentiments towards individual actors, such as the President. Correlation analysis indicates moderate positive associations among all six items (pairwise correlation .31–.56) and internal consistency is high and stable across rounds (α and $\omega_h > .8$; see appendix table A4). Correlations are weaker for the police and judges/magistrates items, consistent with these perceptions being shaped by more direct contact or lower judicial visibility. As a robustness check, I also construct a narrower index excluding the police and judges/magistrates items (Cronbach's α and $\omega_h \geq 0.8$).

[5] The inclusion of actors varies across survey rounds, but all rounds include at least 8 different actors and the same 6 actors are included in every round. See table A3 for the exact actors per round.

[6] These are the office of the presidency, members of parliament, government officials, local government/county assembly members, the police, and judges and magistrates. I group the question on *local government* from round 5 with the question on *county assembly* from round 6 onward, as they were replaced following the full implementation of the 2010 constitutional reform.



(a) Corruption perception index (6–item)

(b) Corruption trend

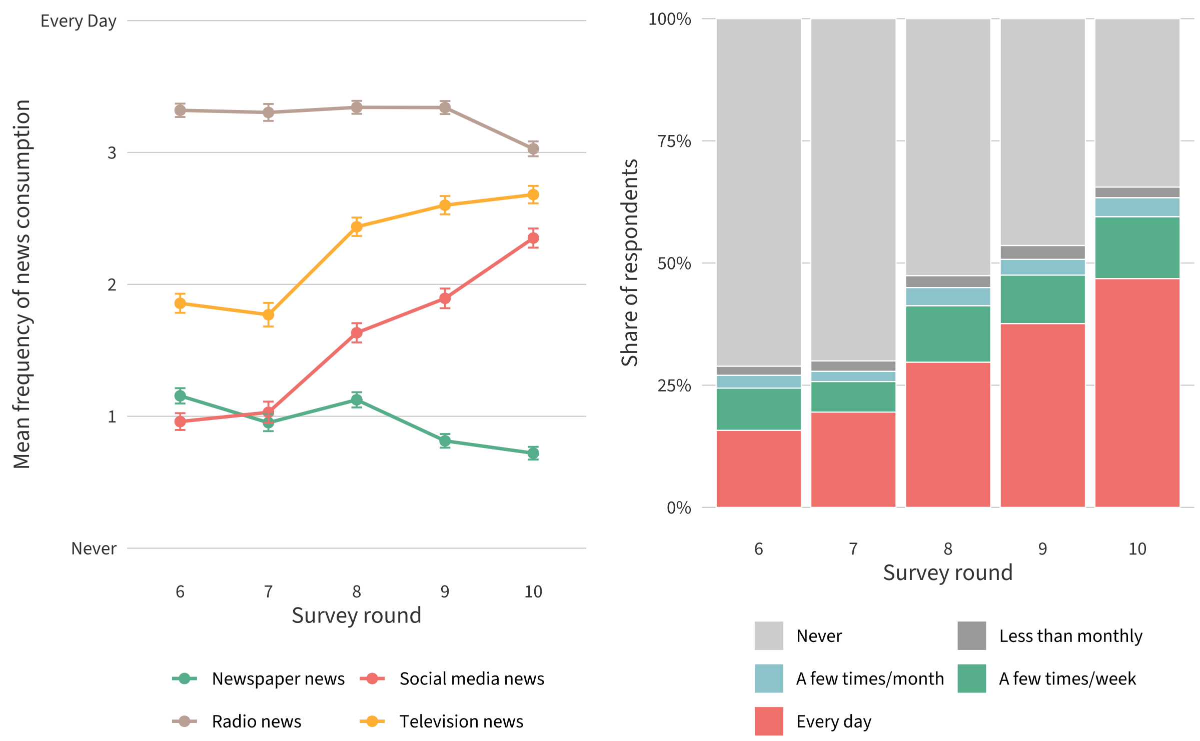
Figure 2: *Distribution of Corruption Perception Measures*. Pooled across rounds. Because the index is based on averaged ordinal items, the distribution reflects a limited set of possible values.

I calculate the corruption perception indices as row-wise averages of the included items so that the resulting measure remains on the original 0–3 response scale. Nonresponse could be substantively meaningful, as respondents have the option to answer "don't know / haven't heard enough", which in a study of information acquisition is itself meaningful rather than missing data at random. To ensure that the index captures a broader underlying perception of corruption rather than specific evaluations of only one or two actors, and to reduce the influence of selective nonresponse, it is calculated only when a minimum number of items is observed (4/6 for the main and 3/4 for the reduced index)[7]. Figure 2a displays the distribution of the index. Appendix table A5 presents the summary statistics and figure A1 shows the trends of the mean response per actor as well as the index; the perceptions of corruption remain remarkably stable across time.

For the responsiveness hypothesis I additionally use a perceived corruption trend variable: ("In your opinion, over the past year, has the level of corruption in this country increased, decreased, or stayed the same?", with responses ranging from 1 = decreased a lot to 5 = increased a lot[8]). This measure is well suited to testing the responsiveness hypothesis. If corruption news coverage has been high in the months preceding the survey, respondents should be more likely to report that corruption has increased. Compared to the level-based

[7]Table A6 presents the percentage of respondents who answered "don't know" per survey round. Most notably, judges and magistrates as well as the office of the presidency most often receive a "don't know" response. The main index could be calculated for 92.94% and the reduced index for 94.34% of respondents, when also accounting for missing responses for unspecified reasons.

[8]The original Afrobarometer coding is reversed; I recode so that higher values indicate higher perceived corruption, consistent with the corruption perception index.



(a) Mean news consumption

(b) Social media news consumption categories

Figure 3: *Development of Digital News Consumption*.

index, which captures relatively stable assessments of institutional corruption, the trend variable captures perceived change and is therefore more likely to reflect the contemporary information environment. Figure 2b displays the distribution of responses.

SM News Consumption

The key independent variable captures the frequency of SM news consumption among respondents. The question reads ("How often do you get news from the following sources: Social media such as Facebook or Twitter?"[9]) that respondents can answer on a 5-point scale from never (0) to every day (4). As seen in figure 3, the use of SM for the consumption of news has increased substantively in the period covered by the data. I run a separate analysis using a dichotomized version of the variable ("at least a few times a week" = 1), but chose to use the categorical measure for the main analysis to avoid inducing an arbitrary cut-off and to preserve information. I report results using dummies (at least a few times a week) in the appendix (table B6).

[9]In rounds 8–10 the question changes slightly to "such as Facebook, Twitter, WhatsApp or others?". This reflects a changing understanding of SM but could also influence the responses by pointing to a very common messaging platform. However, as the growth in the internet news use variable shows a similar trend in round 8 and 9, I discount the concern here.

Corruption Reporting Salience

The second independent variable is corruption reporting salience which is drawn from the Machine Learning for Peace (ML4P) dataset by Moratz et al. (2025). This data tracks monthly media attention to 20 civic-space event categories across 65 aid receiving countries from 2012 onwards. ML4P is based on the HQMARC corpus of high-quality domestic media[10] and classifies articles using human-supervised machine-learning models to event categories, one of which is corruption. The dataset aims to cover a gap to better understand civic space dynamics in day-to-day life in addition to expert-coded international indicators (e.g., Freedom House (2025) and Nord et al. (2026)). In particular, the granularity at a monthly level is useful for a variety of inquiries.

From the ML4P data, I derive the normalized monthly share of all Kenyan news coverage devoted to corruption, which captures the relative salience of corruption in the domestic news agenda and makes trends more comparable over time. Corruption coverage is identified using keyword-based classification, with articles that feature accountability-related content – such as legal proceedings, arrests, or dismissals – double-coded as both corruption and the respective accountability category[11]. This measure is well suited to the argument of this thesis, as it approximates the visibility of corruption-related information in the broader information environment rather than objective corruption incidence. I use the three month average prior to the primary fieldwork month of each Afrobarometer survey to account for the fact that corruption perceptions from the media might be stickier over time and not driven by instantaneous exposure[12]. Figure 4 shows the development of the ML4P corruption reporting data over time in relation to the Afrobarometer survey periods. The responsiveness hypothesis treats this measure as a moderator of the SM effect, since users should respond more strongly to corruption coverage than non-users.

Control Variables

I include four individual-level controls that previous research suggests could be potential confounders of the relationship: Education, age, an urban-rural dummy, and the Lived Poverty Index (LPI). Education drives the frequency of SM news consumption by increasing digital literacy (IV), while it is also a well-established predictor of more critical normative standards

[10]More than 95% of the corpus is made up of domestic sources. In the case of Kenya, these are Kenya Broadcasting Corporation (state-owned public broadcaster), Citizen Digital, Nation.Africa (both digital news platforms), and The EastAfrican (regional weekly newspaper).

[11]The corruption classifier identifies articles containing keywords such as *embezzle*, *bribe*, *fraud*, *corrupt*, *graft*, *procurement*, and *laundering*. Articles in the arrest, legal action, and purge categories that contain these keywords are double-coded as corruption. Conversely, corruption articles featuring accountability keywords (e.g., *investigate*, *prosecute*, *trial*, *arrest*, *detain*, *resign*, *dismiss*) are double-coded in the respective accountability category. See Moratz et al. (2025) for the full coding scheme.

[12]Any choice of months for the average calculation induces some form of arbitrary cut-off. I use three months as a plausible window for cumulative media exposure. I also test one- and 12-month alternatives in the robustness section (see appendix tables B8 to B13).

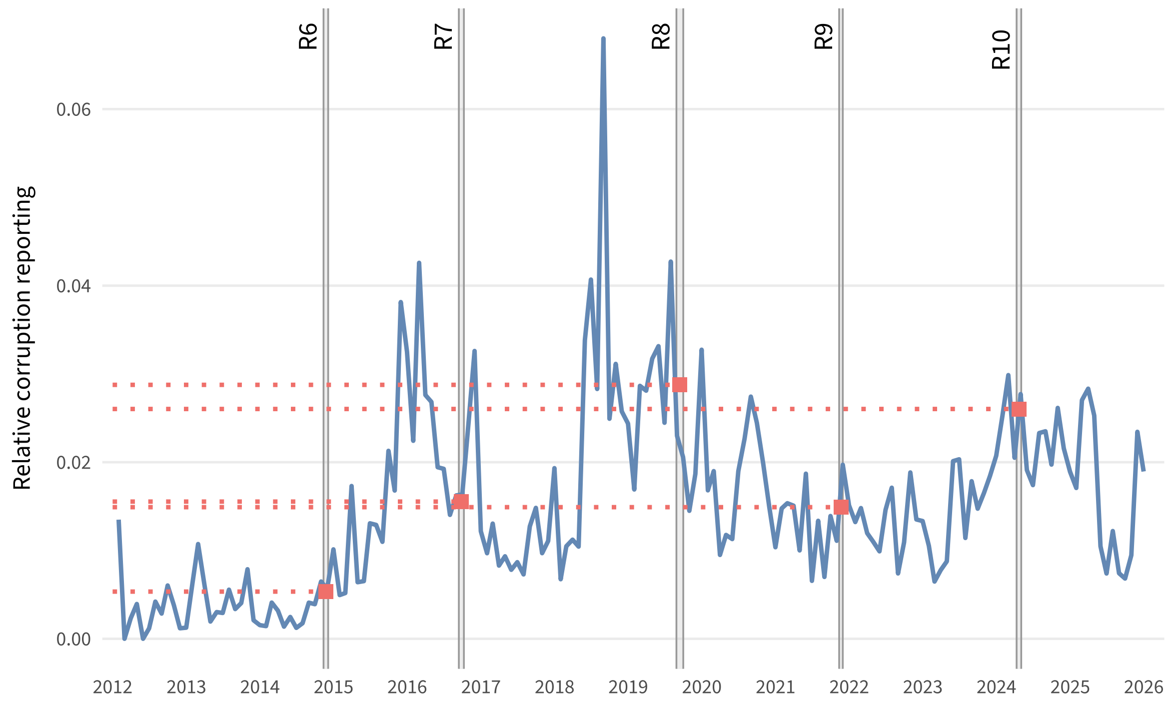


Figure 4: *Monthly Corruption Reporting in Kenyan News, 2012-2025*. The solid line shows the normalized share of reporting devoted to corruption. Vertical lines mark the periods of Afrobarometer surveys used in the analysis and the red dots the average corruption reporting in the three months prior to the respective survey.

regarding corruption (DV) (Melgar et al., 2010). The original ten-point education scale was collapsed into four theoretically meaningful categories reflecting institutional breaks: No or informal education, primary, secondary, and post-secondary (see appendix figure A2). Age is a significant driver of both SM use and corruption perceptions in general and in Kenya in particular the perception and tolerance towards corruption vary across age cohorts (Cheeseman et al., 2024; Nyabola, 2018). Finally, the urban-rural divide (coded rural = 0 and urban = 1) and lived poverty are included as they determine the accessibility of mobile network coverage and hardware (IV), while simultaneously plausibly shaping an individual's personal exposure to administrative bribery and other sorts of corruption (DV). Lived poverty is measured using the Afrobarometer Lived Poverty Index, constructed as the mean of five items capturing how often respondents went without food, clean water, medical care, cooking fuel, and cash income (never = 0, to always = 4). The descriptive statistics for all analysis variables can be found in table 1[13]. For details on the wording and exact coding of each question, consult the harmonization table in the replication materials.

I choose not to control for province and mobile network coverage. Province of residence is

[13]In a descriptive analysis, regular SM news consumers (dummy variable) are on average nine years younger, substantially better educated, more likely to reside in urban areas, and report lower levels of lived poverty than non-regular consumers, indicating that all four control variables constitute plausible back-door paths requiring adjustment.

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics of Analysis Variables

Variable	Obs	Mean	SD	Min	Max	Missing
Dependent variables						
Corruption perception (6-item)	12,936	1.58	0.57	0	3	659
Corruption perception (4-item)	12,825	1.52	0.62	0	3	770
Corruption trend	10,913	3.95	1.23	1	5	2,682
Independent variables						
Social media news consumption	11,119	1.60	1.83	0	4	2,476
Social media news (regular, 0/1)	11,119	0.40	0.49	0	1	2,476
Corruption news salience (3m)	11,196	0.02	0.01	0.01	0.03	2,399
Control variables						
Age	13,563	36.36	14.15	18	112	32
Education	13,550	1.76	0.86	0	3	45
Urban	13,595	0.35	0.48	0	1	0
Lived Poverty Index	13,595	1.21	0.86	0	4	0

Note. Means and standard deviations use Afrobarometer within-country weights.

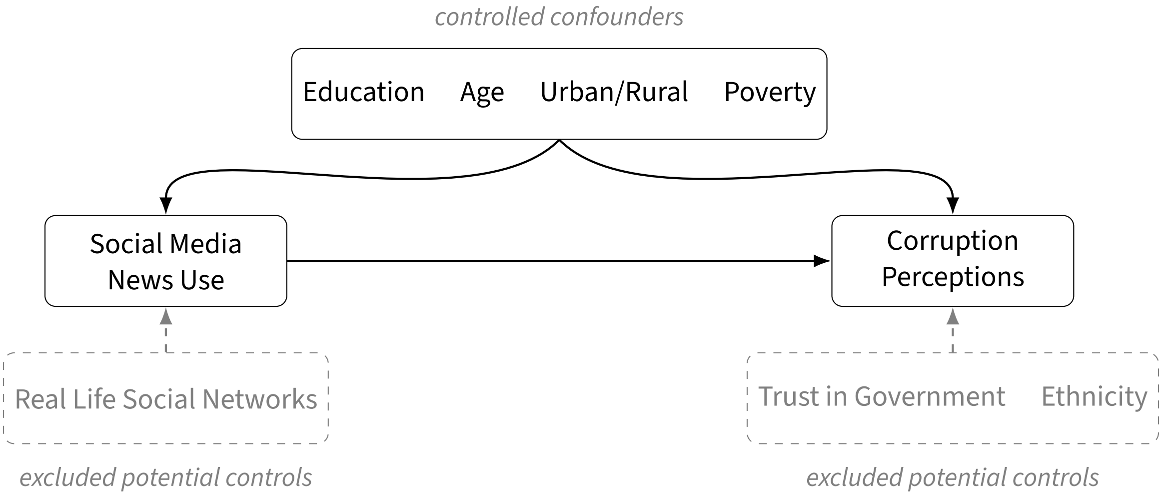


Figure 5: *Control Variable Inclusion.* The dashed gray box groups represent theoretically relevant variables that I assume to only affect one of the two main variables and therefore not bias the *relationship* between them.

not included as a control in the main specification, as there is no clear theoretical mechanism through which province would independently affect both SM use and corruption perceptions conditional on the included controls. Appendix Figure A3 shows that corruption perceptions and SM news consumption vary only modestly across Kenya's eight former provinces, with the exception of higher digital media use in Nairobi. As a robustness check, I re-estimate the main models with province fixed effects and find no substantively different results (see appendix table B7). I also choose not to include mobile network coverage, which is reported by Afrobarometer interviewers, as the average coverage per survey round is above 98%. The assumptions that guide the inclusion and exclusion of control variables are summarized in figure 5 (Rohrer, 2018).

In addition to the confounders identified above, I include the frequency of radio, television, and newspaper news consumption as competing information channels. These are not strict confounders, but they address the alternative explanation that the observed association reflects general news attentiveness rather than a social-media-specific effect. If the coefficient on SM news consumption remains positive after conditioning on traditional media use, this supports the interpretation that SM provides an independent informational channel for corruption-related content. These are measured using the same question battery as SM news consumption.

5.2 Identification Strategy

The goal of the identification strategy is to *identify* the effect (β) of a *treatment*, in this case mainly SM news use, on an *outcome* (Y), here corruption perceptions. To do this I conduct an OLS multiple regression analysis considering the pooled repeated cross-section design of the Afrobarometer survey using fixed effects (δ):

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta \; Social\ Media\ News_{it} + \mathbf{X}_{it}'\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \delta_t + e_{it}$$

The identifying assumption is that, conditional on the control vector $\mathbf{X}$ and the fixed effects δ, SM news use is uncorrelated with the error term e. Regression thereby implicitly compares respondents with similar age, education, urbanization, and lived poverty – effectively matching SM users to non-users who are otherwise alike on these observable dimensions (Angrist & Pischke, 2015; Sarafanov, 2026). In principle, a change in the treatment variable could then be interpreted as a causal effect on the outcome by blocking back-door paths that bias the relationship. However, this assumption relies on correctly identifying and measuring all confounders – observed and unobserved. This condition is rarely fully met – and bordering on impossible for observational research – and illustrates one of the central limitations of non-experimental data (Rohrer, 2018). Plausible unobserved confounders include personality traits and the heterogeneous experiences of news consumption that a single survey item necessarily flattens. I therefore interpret my estimates as conditional associations rather than actual causal effects.

For the analysis of the effect of corruption reporting on corruption perceptions, I employ an interaction effect between the two variables. This is reflected in the regression equation:

$$\begin{aligned} Y_{it} = \alpha &+ \beta_1 \; Social\ Media\ News_{it} + \beta_2 \; Corruption\ Reporting_t \\ &+ \beta_3 \left(Social\ Media\ News_{it} \times Corruption\ Reporting_t \right) + \mathbf{X}_{it}'\boldsymbol{\gamma} + e_{it} \end{aligned}$$

A key limitation here is that corruption news salience varies only at the survey-round level, leaving very little independent variation with which to estimate cross-level responsiveness effects. Also, due to the perfect collinearity between the corruption salience and round variables, the fixed effects per round have to be dropped. In other words, this implies that all survey round variation is captured by levels of corruption reporting. This, however, is unrealistic: Survey rounds differ in many other characteristics, such as presidential approval, election season, or political scandals. This is a fundamental weakness of the design and data and should be kept in mind when interpreting results.

While some of the drawbacks of the use of observational data cannot be overcome by research design, I conduct a variety of robustness checks to assess the sensitivity of the main results. First, I re-estimate all models using a binary operationalization of SM news use (regular vs. non-regular) instead of the continuous 0–4 frequency measure, to ensure that results are not driven by a functional form assumption. Second, I replace the main corruption perception index with the perceived corruption trend variable as an alternative dependent variable, which captures whether respondents believe corruption has increased or decreased rather than the level of perceived involvement. Third, I add province fixed effects to account for unobserved spatial heterogeneity, although there is limited theoretical justification for province-level confounding conditional on the included controls. Fourth, I estimate the main specification separately for each survey round to examine whether the association between SM news use and corruption perceptions is stable across time or driven by particular rounds. Throughout, I present a stepwise model-building sequence from bivariate to full specification to assess the sensitivity of the treatment variable to the progressive inclusion of individual-level confounders and competing media channels. If the treatment effect β remains stable, this provides indirect evidence that omitted variable bias from unobserved confounders is likely modest (Angrist & Pischke, 2015).

Finally, regarding statistical inference, the Afrobarometer employs a stratified, clustered, multi-stage sampling design in which respondents are drawn from primary sampling units (PSUs). Observations within the same PSU are likely to share unobserved local characteristics, such as media infrastructure, exposure to corruption, or political climate, which may induce within-cluster correlation of the error terms. Ideally, standard errors should therefore be clustered at the PSU level. However, the publicly available Afrobarometer datasets do not include PSU identifiers, precluding cluster-robust inference at this level. I therefore report HC2 heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors throughout the main analysis (Cameron & Miller, 2015).

Regressions are estimated unweighted. While Afrobarometer provides survey weights that correct for unequal selection probabilities, my estimation strategy is a conditional association rather than a population-representative mean, and therefore I do not weight the main regressions. I verify in appendix (tables B1 to B3) that weighted estimates are substantively identical to the unweighted results. Descriptive statistics, however, are reported using survey weights.

All models are estimated in R (R Core Team, 2026) using the `estimatr` package for heteroskedasticity-robust inference, `marginaleffects` package for marginal effects calculations, and `modelsummary` for table exports. I used generative AI tools (`claude.ai` and `notebook.lm`)

Table 2: Information Hypothesis: Social Media News Use and Corruption Perceptions

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Social Media News (0–4)	0.010***	0.010**	0.007†	0.008*
	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.004)
Age			0.003***	0.003***
			(0.000)	(0.000)
Education			0.055***	0.058***
			(0.008)	(0.008)
Urban			0.102***	0.102***
			(0.012)	(0.012)
Lived Poverty Index			0.099***	0.099***
			(0.008)	(0.008)
Radio News				-0.004
				(0.005)
Newspaper News				-0.009†
				(0.005)
TV News				0.003
				(0.004)
Round FE	—	✓	✓	✓
R^2	0.001	0.002	0.033	0.034
Adj. R^2	0.001	0.001	0.032	0.033
Num. Obs.	10626	10626	10580	10559

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$
HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.
Round fixed effects included where indicated.

to troubleshoot and support the writing of R code and LaTeX formatting, and for proofreading and identifying unclear passages in the text. No text, analysis, or interpretation was generated by AI.

6 Results

6.1 Information and Maturation

Table 2 presents the regression results testing the information hypothesis (i.e., higher corruption perceptions among respondents who use SM for news). The SM news coefficient is positive across all specifications but small in magnitude ($\approx$ .01 per unit on a scale from 0–4) and shrinks once demographic controls are introduced. Education, urban residence, and lived poverty are substantially stronger predictors of corruption perceptions than SM news use. For comparison, moving from no formal education to post-secondary education while keeping other variables at their sample means (age = 36, LPI = 1.22, survey round = 8) shifts predicted corruption perceptions from 1.42 to 1.59 – a difference of 0.17 points, roughly six times the magnitude of the full SM news effect (.03 points from 1.52 to 1.55). Figure 6 depicts predicted values of major variables.

To assess whether the information effect is driven by a single round or is stable across

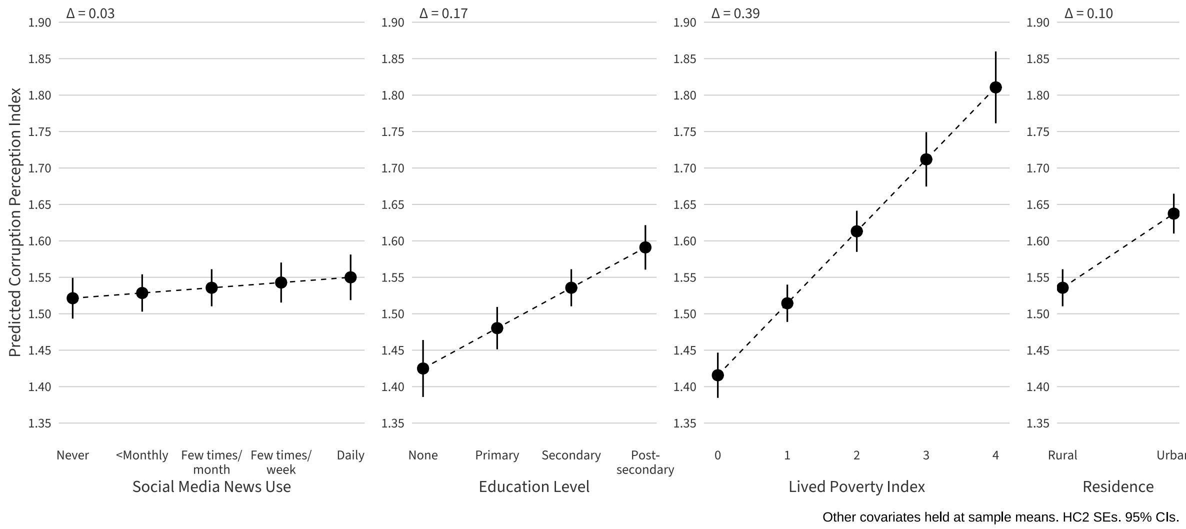


Figure 6: *Comparative Effect Sizes Using Predicted Values*. Values from model 3, table 2.

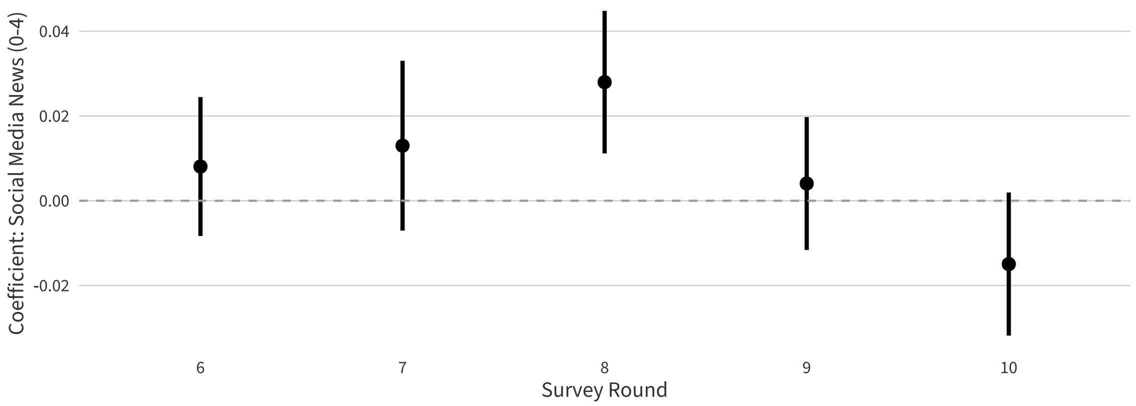


Figure 7: *Stability of the SM News Coefficient Across Rounds*. Round-specific estimates of the SM news coefficient on the corruption index, from the controlled model with demographic controls (age, education, urban/rural, lived poverty index). HC2 robust standard errors. 95% CIs.

waves, I estimate the controlled model separately for each round (see figure 7). The coefficients are generally small and centered near zero, with most confidence intervals crossing the zero line. Rounds 6–9 show positive coefficients, while round 10 shows a negative coefficient that falls just short of the 95% threshold. Only round 8 has a significant association between SM news consumption and corruption perceptions. This pattern is also inconsistent with $H_{\text{Maturation}}$, which predicted a widening gap across rounds; the round-specific coefficients show no upward trend.

The results are robust to a variety of tests. The reduced index produces essentially the same results and the results for the trend variable in the full model are also similar to the ones presented here (see appendix tables B4 and B5). The results are also robust to the replacement of the SM news variable with a dummy version and the inclusion of province fixed effects (appendix tables B6 and B7).

Table 3: Baseline Test: Corruption News Salience and Corruption Perceptions

	Corruption Perception Index			Corruption Trend		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Corruption News Salience	0.700	-1.229†	-1.469*	-7.628***	-10.937***	-11.596***
	(0.629)	(0.634)	(0.663)	(1.358)	(1.358)	(1.415)
Age		0.002***	0.003***		0.004***	0.004***
		(0.000)	(0.000)		(0.001)	(0.001)
Education		0.061***	0.058***		0.066***	0.058***
		(0.007)	(0.008)		(0.015)	(0.017)
Urban		0.104***	0.103***		0.084***	0.087***
		(0.012)	(0.012)		(0.025)	(0.026)
Lived Poverty Index		0.095***	0.096***		0.197***	0.194***
		(0.007)	(0.008)		(0.014)	(0.014)
Social Media News (0–4)			0.006			0.026**
			(0.004)			(0.008)
Radio News			-0.003			0.002
			(0.005)			(0.009)
Newspaper News			-0.007			-0.021*
			(0.005)			(0.010)
TV News			0.002			-0.011
			(0.004)			(0.008)
R^2	0.000	0.032	0.033	0.003	0.023	0.024
Adj. R^2	0.000	0.032	0.032	0.003	0.023	0.023
Num. Obs.	10691	10645	10559	10913	10868	10780

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$
HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

6.2 Responsiveness

The responsiveness hypothesis posits that SM users are more responsive to the corruption news environment – i.e., when corruption coverage is high, SM users should update their perceptions more than non-users. Testing this requires two steps: First, establishing that corruption news salience is associated with corruption perceptions at all (baseline test); second, testing whether SM news use moderates that relationship (interaction test). I use both the corruption index and the perceived corruption trend variable as dependent variables.

The baseline test is presented in table 3 using the corruption perception and the trend DV. For the perception DV (models 1–3), the salience coefficient is positive in the bivariate model but turns negative and marginally significant once controls are added. For the corruption trend DV (models 4–6), the effect of corruption news salience is much stronger and consistently highly significant. SM news remains positively related to the perceived corruption trend, in line with the information hypothesis[14]. Control variables are signed as expected and statistically significant. The negative sign runs against the hypothesized positive relationship; possible explanations are explored in the discussion.

To contextualize the magnitude, I compute predicted values holding covariates at their

[14] This association disappears when round fixed effects replace the salience measure, suggesting it captures between-round variation rather than a within-round information effect.

Table 4: Responsiveness Test: Salience × Social Media News Use

	Corruption Perception Index			Corruption Trend		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Corruption News Salience	0.443	-1.533†	-1.563†	-5.840**	-10.006***	-9.852***
	(0.848)	(0.851)	(0.855)	(1.801)	(1.798)	(1.812)
Social Media News (0–4)	0.011	0.003	0.005	0.032*	0.040*	0.050**
	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.008)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.017)
Salience × SM News	-0.036	0.127	0.065	-1.345†	-1.075	-1.226
	(0.357)	(0.352)	(0.354)	(0.776)	(0.770)	(0.775)
Age		0.003***	0.003***		0.004***	0.004***
		(0.000)	(0.000)		(0.001)	(0.001)
Education		0.056***	0.058***		0.049**	0.058***
		(0.008)	(0.008)		(0.016)	(0.017)
Urban		0.102***	0.103***		0.071**	0.087***
		(0.012)	(0.012)		(0.025)	(0.026)
Lived Poverty Index		0.097***	0.096***		0.200***	0.193***
		(0.007)	(0.008)		(0.014)	(0.014)
Radio News			-0.003			0.002
			(0.005)			(0.009)
Newspaper News			-0.007			-0.022*
			(0.005)			(0.010)
TV News			0.002			-0.011
			(0.004)			(0.008)
R^2	0.001	0.032	0.033	0.003	0.024	0.024
Adj. R^2	0.001	0.032	0.032	0.003	0.023	0.023
Num. Obs.	10626	10580	10559	10847	10802	10780

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$
HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

sample means (age = 36, education = 2, urban = 0, LPI = 1.22). Moving from the lowest-salience round (R6, salience = .005) to the highest-salience round (R8, salience = .029) shifts predicted corruption trend scores from 4.07 to 3.82, a decrease of 0.25 points on the 1–5 scale. For comparison, the same shift in salience moves predicted corruption perception levels from 1.56 to 1.53 – a difference of 0.03 points on the 0–3 scale. The salience effect on the trend variable is roughly eight times larger in standardized terms than on the level index.

Table 4 shows regressions of the second part of the responsiveness hypothesis: Do respondents who use SM for news react more strongly to a change in corruption news salience? The main coefficient of interest, the interaction effect of corruption news salience and SM news consumption, is small, switches signs across specifications, and remains insignificant (see figure 8). Similar to the previous models, corruption news salience is negatively associated with both DVs but more strongly so with the trend. SM news is positively associated with both, but only significantly with the trend. This means that while corruption news salience does not interact with SM news consumption, SM news consumption is still associated with a higher perceived trend of corruption. In sum, higher corruption news salience is associated with lower perceived corruption – much stronger for the trend variable – but SM users are not significantly different from non-users.

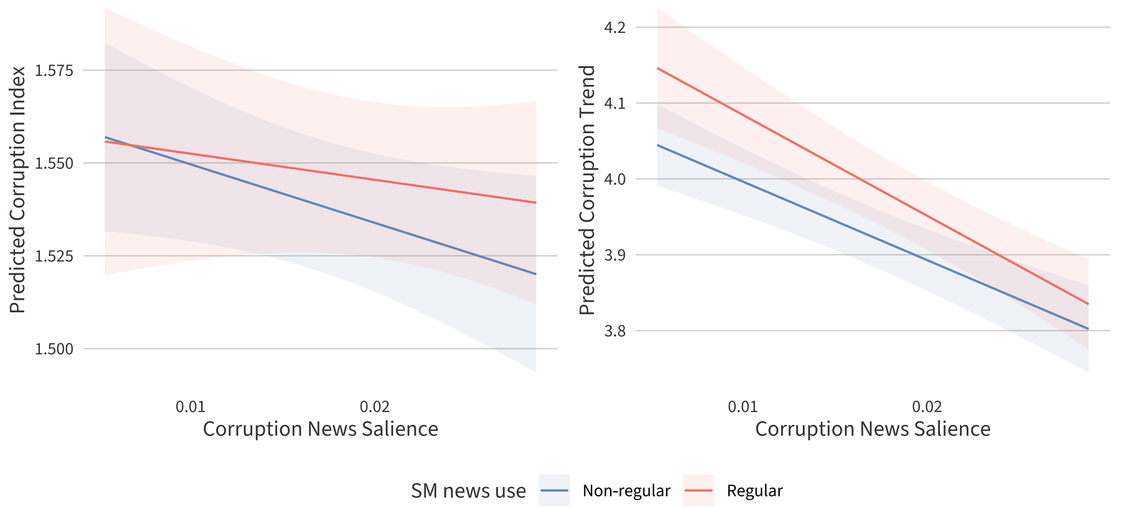


Figure 8: *Predicted Corruption Perceptions by News Salience and SM Use*. Predicted corruption perceptions as a function of ML4P corruption news salience, separately for regular social media news users and non-users. Predictions are obtained from estimates of the interaction model (models 3 and 6 from table 4), holding covariates at their mean values. Confidence intervals based on HC2 robust standard errors.

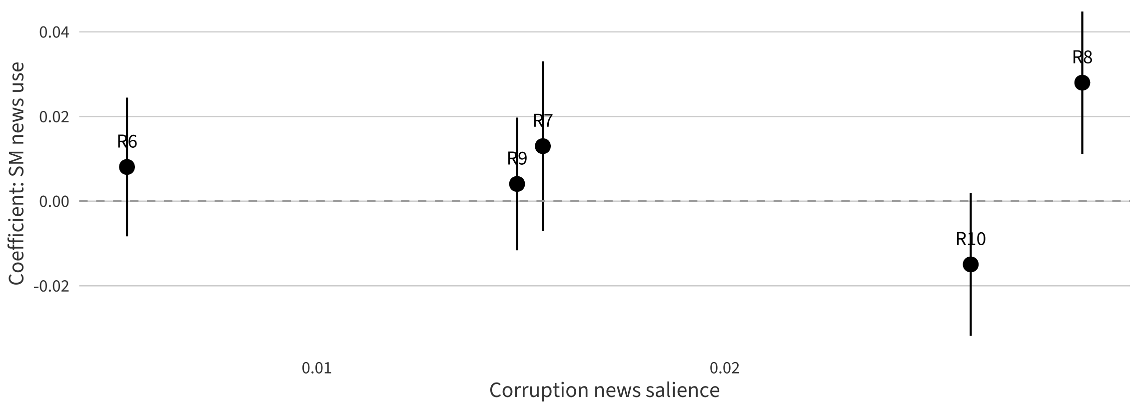


Figure 9: *Round-Specific SM News Coefficients by Corruption News Salience*. Round-specific estimates of the SM news coefficient on the corruption perception index from the controlled model, plotted against the three-month average of corruption news salience preceding each survey round. HC2 robust standard errors. 95% CIs.

Looking at the effect of SM news consumption on corruption levels separated by round (figure 9), there is no clear pattern between the two variables: The two rounds with the highest corruption news salience show effect estimates of opposite signs – an observation that is re-visited in the discussion (section 7.3). The effect on the trend variable by round is shown in the appendix figure B1 and similarly supports a null finding. Robustness checks for this finding are presented in the next subsection.

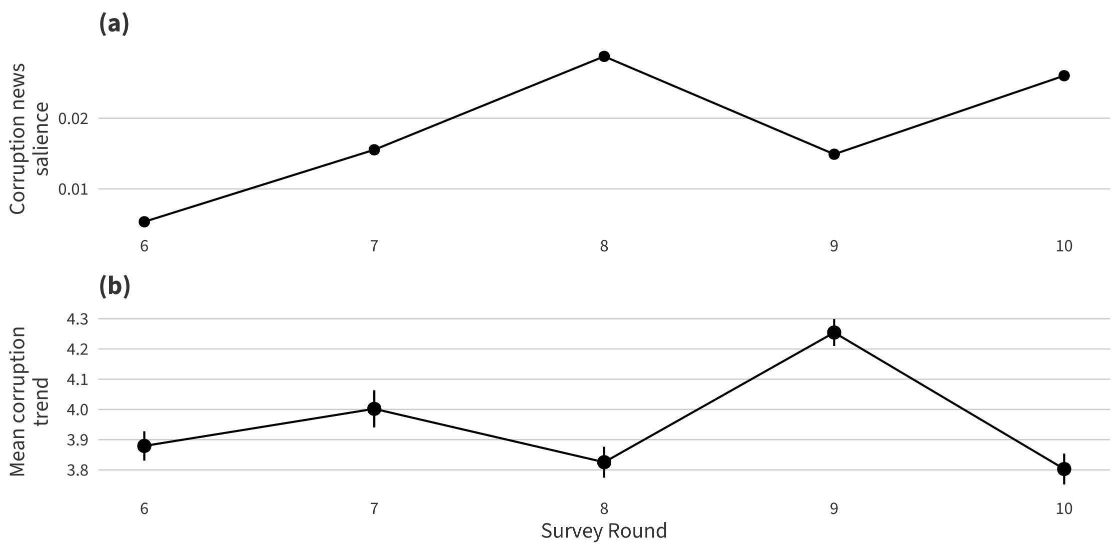


Figure 10: *Corruption News Salience and Corruption Trend Timeline*. Panel (a) shows the three-month average of normalized corruption news coverage prior to each survey round. Panel (b) shows the round-level mean of the corruption trend variable (1–5 scale). 95% CIs shown in (b).

6.3 Exploring the Salience-Trend Relationship

To investigate the strong negative association between corruption news salience and perceived corruption trends, I conduct additional analyses and robustness checks. Figure 10 shows a clear inverse pattern: Rounds with higher salience (R8, R10) show lower perceived corruption increases, while the moderate-salience round (R9) shows the highest trend score. The R6–R7 transition is an exception, where both measures increase simultaneously. This pattern illustrates the strong negative coefficient found in the individual-level regressions from models 4-6 in tables 3 and 4. It is important to keep in mind that this is an ecological-level visualization and shows 5 round-level means rather than individual observations.

To check whether the finding is driven by a single round, I re-estimate the model excluding Round 9, which shows an unusually high trend score (4.25 vs. 3.80–4.00 elsewhere) despite only moderate salience (see appendix table B14). The coefficient shrinks but remains highly significant. The negative salience–trend relationship is not an artifact of a single outlier round. The finding also replicates when using 1-month or 12-month salience windows rather than the 3-month average (β = -7.98, $p < .001$ and -6.86, $p < .001$ respectively), ruling out that results are driven by the temporal aggregation choice (see appendix tables B9 and B12). Results are also robust to survey weighting (B3) and province fixed effects (B7).

7 Discussion

7.1 The Information Effect: Small but Real

Kenyans who use SM for news regularly perceive more corruption than those who do not. SM news consumption is positively associated with corruption perceptions across all pooled specifications and in four out of five survey rounds, though only significant in round 8. The association is robust to alternative specifications. The effect size, however, is small and inconsistent across rounds. This matches the broader pattern of small observational effects relative to the large effects found in survey experiments (Incerti, 2020).

Several factors may explain the limited magnitude. First, corruption perceptions in Kenya are remarkably stable across rounds with very limited variation (appendix figure A1) suggesting they are not strongly shaped by current events. SM may add marginal information to an already settled perception of high levels of corruption among Kenyans, regardless of where they get their news from. This is in line with findings from Gingerich (2009) that only *high* levels of corruption exposure induce protest participation, while low levels do not: News provides low-to-moderate exposure rather than the concentrated shocks studied experimentally. Second, demographic controls reduce the effect size, suggesting that much of the raw SM-corruption association reflects compositional differences: SM users are younger, more educated, more urban, and less poor – all characteristics independently associated with higher corruption perceptions. Third, the effect varies by round, possibly reflecting the shift in SM use from niche to mainstream over the study period. Early adopters (rounds 6–7) likely differed systematically from later, broader user populations. Another reason could be the national context of the respective survey period, an argument further investigated below.

Despite its small size, the effect should not be dismissed and is consistent with Guriev et al. (2021) finding at the macro level that mobile broadband expansion increases corruption perceptions, and with Denisova-Schmidt et al. (2019) finding at the individual level that exposure to corruption-related SM content can shift attitudes.

7.2 Null Responsiveness and Maturation

What is much easier to answer is the question whether SM increases responsiveness to changes in corruption reporting: This hypothesis finds no support in the data. The interaction term between corruption news salience and SM news consumption is small, inconsistently signed, and statistically insignificant across all specifications. Figure 8 shows this: Predicted corruption perceptions for SM users and non-users show no diverging effects.

One explanation is that corruption news salience, measured at the round level, operates through general public discourse rather than through individual media channels. If high-profile corruption coverage reaches all respondents – regardless of their personal news diet - everyone would be similarly affected. In this reading, the null interaction does not mean that salience is irrelevant, but that its effects are not channeled disproportionately through SM. This is consistent with Arias et al. (2019) finding that information diffuses through social networks beyond direct recipients, and with Enríquez et al. (2024b) observation that high-saturation information environments activate social propagation mechanisms beyond the initially targeted audience. Credibility may also play a role; Klaveren et al. (2024) show that SM corruption reports are discounted relative to traditional sources, so users may encounter more content but update less.

A complementary explanation concerns statistical power. Salience varies across only five round-level values, leaving very limited variation with which to detect a cross-level interaction. Even if SM users were somewhat more responsive, the design may lack the precision to distinguish this from the baseline salience effect. ML4P's monthly granularity is only exploited to a limited extent in the present design; future research with more granular temporal variation in media exposure – for example, exploiting within-round differences in fieldwork timing (see, e.g., Mbithi & Kijima, 2026) or regional variation – would provide a stronger test of differential responsiveness.

The maturation hypothesis similarly finds no support. The interaction between SM news use and a linear survey round trend is small and insignificant, and the round-specific coefficient plots show no systematic upward or downward trajectory in the SM–corruption association across rounds 6 through 10 (see 7). One explanation is the shift in user composition from politically attentive early adopters – what Nyabola (2018) calls Kenya's "first digital decade" – toward a broader, more mainstream population.

These null findings carry substantive implications. In the Kenyan context, SM functions as one source of corruption information among many, not a uniquely powerful channel that differentially sensitizes its users.

7.3 Round 8 and Round 10: What changed?

The estimated effect of SM news use varies markedly across rounds (figure 9). Most strikingly, rounds 8 and 10 show the strongest and weakest associations respectively – despite both exhibiting high corruption news salience and low mean trend scores. Why was SM a driver for corruption perceptions in 2019 and what changed in 2024? To better understand this, I examine the Kenyan political and media context during the two survey windows. This is not a causal test but a plausibility check that points to avenues for future research.

The period leading up to survey round 8 (August 28–October 1, 2019) was characterized by several high-profile corruption scandals and investigations. The political climate at the time was still shaped by the aftermath of the March 2018 "Handshake" between long-time opposition leader Raila Odinga and President Uhuru Kenyatta after the disputed 2017 election. Kenyatta declared the fight against corruption the main objective of his second term and engaged in high-visibility activities tackling corruption, including so-called "lifestyle audits" for all public servants to declare the origins of their wealth (Democracy Chronicles, 2018). At the same time, the newly-appointed Director of Public Prosecutions started a series of high-profile prosecutions through 2018–2019 that dominated headlines. Most prominently, Finance Minister Henry Rotich became the first sitting minister arrested on corruption charges in July of 2019. Several other high-ranking government officials and county governors were investigated and later arrested (Freedom House, 2020a). Around the same time, the online hashtags “#StopTheseThieves” and “#SwitchoffKPLC” gained prominence and led to protests against the country’s main electricity provider over inflated customer bills. (Freedom House, 2020b; Nyabola, 2018).

Surveying for round 10 (April 10–May 3, 2024), on the other hand, took place in the weeks leading up to the major June 2024 protests against the Finance Bill. President William Ruto (inaugurated September 2022) had campaigned on a “bottom-up” anti-corruption platform but quickly withdrew charges against a number of Ruto’s allies. The major story at the time concerned a fake fertilizer scandal but there was no single prosecution or scandal that matched the attention and scope of survey round 8. The Finance Bill had just been introduced in parliament towards the end of the survey period but had not yet gained the visibility that later led to major protests (Freedom House, 2025; Mbithi & Kijima, 2026). Notably, the June 2024 protests are widely seen as SM-driven, making it especially striking that no SM-user differences were detected in the weeks immediately preceding them (Ingutia, 2025).

In the meantime, SM use had become even more mainstream and shifted towards short-form videos; Kenya became the country with the highest consumption of TikTok for news in the world (Reuters Institute, 2025). Between the two survey rounds, credible reports of paid disinformation campaigns also came to light, in which SM influencers were paid for daily posts on Twitter and WhatsApp on behalf of government actors (e.g., Madung & Obilo, 2021). It is unclear if similar activities were taking place during the survey period, but even if they did not, it could have reshaped the dynamics of online platforms and the trust users place in them. The round 10 survey period also falls after the change of ownership of Twitter to Elon Musk and its re-branding as X. One of the major online activist groups often shaping discourse – Kenyans on Twitter, also known under the hashtag “#KOT” (see Nyabola, 2018) – could have been affected by this change and the ongoing change of X’s algorithm (see Gauthier et al., 2026, on the political effects of X’s new algorithm).

Descriptively, two major differences between the survey periods highlight avenues for future research: First, the survey periods were shaped by different levels and types of corruption reporting. Round 8 took place in an environment of *scandal-driven* anti-corruption coverage, while round 10 was shaped by more *routine, low-intensity* reporting. This distinction becomes analytically important in the next subsection. Potentially, the features of SM favor scandalous and viral events rather than ongoing corruption coverage. This is an important avenue for future research that could examine effects of *types of events* of corruption reporting. Second, SM news had become mainstream and trust could have declined due to disinformation campaigns and changes in algorithms and platforms.

7.4 The Accountability Signal Interpretation

The most striking finding of this thesis is the relationship between the corruption news environment and perceived corruption trends. Across all specifications, corruption news salience is strongly and negatively associated with the perceived corruption trend. In other words, respondents surveyed in periods of higher corruption news coverage are *less* likely to report that corruption has increased. The effect is large: Moving from the lowest- to the highest-salience round shifts predicted trend scores by 0.25 points on the 1–5 scale, a substantively meaningful shift. The finding survives the exclusion of the most influential round, replicates under 1- and 12-month salience windows, and is robust to survey weighting and province fixed effects. This runs opposite to the baseline prediction of the responsiveness hypothesis. Why, then, does higher coverage predict *lower* perceived increases?

One interpretation is that high corruption news coverage functions as an accountability signal. When media actively report on corruption, e.g., with investigations, audits, or arrests, citizens may interpret this not as evidence that corruption is worsening, but as evidence that the system is working: Corruption is being exposed, discussed, and potentially addressed. In this reading, the negative coefficient does not indicate that respondents are unaware of corruption, but rather that they perceive the *trajectory* as improving precisely because corruption is being brought to light. It also clarifies the round 8 and 10 contrast; round 8 coverage was structured around visible enforcement (the Rotich arrest, DPP prosecutions, lifestyle audits), while round 10 coverage centered on the absence of enforcement. Both patterns are consistent with the framework.

This interpretation finds support on a measurement level. ML4P's corruption salience measure codes some words that are also linked to accountability under the corruption measure. For example, "investigate", "arrest", or "resign" all get counted towards the corruption measurement and could thereby bias the intended measurement of an episode of corruption scandals in the opposite direction: Levels of *high accountability* and strong fight against corruption are more strongly correlated with *lower corruption trend* perceptions. The ML4P corruption and accountability measures move broadly in parallel (appendix figure C1).

Circling back to the broader literature, this interpretation also finds support. Studies on media and corruption accountability, including Ferraz and Finan (2008) on Brazilian audits, Mbithi and Kijima (2026) on Kenyan county audits, and Larreguy et al. (2020) on Mexican municipal media, all study coverage triggered by institutional accountability mechanisms, not by corruption itself. This parallels Chang et al. (2010): Italy's "Clean Hands" period, the most intensively covered corruption episode in the country's postwar history, was precisely a period of unprecedented judicial accountability, not a period of unusually high corruption. The ML4P salience measure may be capturing a similar dynamic in Kenya, where spikes in corruption reporting coincide with moments of institutional action rather than institutional failure. Similarly, in an environment where expectations are very low, the fact that *any* action is taken can be considered an improvement – consistent with the finding by Arias et al. (2022) that Mexican voters reward mayors who "only" misallocate up to 40% of funds.

The different effects of the level and trend measures further support this interpretation. The corruption perception index – which captures how many officials respondents believe to be corrupt – is largely unresponsive to salience. This indicates that Kenyans' beliefs about corruption are deeply rooted in personal experience, cultural attitudes, and institutional expectations and not easily changed by reporting. This is consistent with the relative stability of institutions (Rothstein, 2011) and continued effects of the origins of mistrust in Africa (Nunn & Wantchekon, 2011). The trend variable, by contrast, asks respondents to assess *change*. If respondents observe that corruption is being discussed, reported on, and investigated, they may conclude that corruption is being addressed, even if their overall assessment of corruption levels remains high. Nevertheless, the contrast between a fluctuating trend variable and a stable level variable raises an important puzzle for measurement and future research.

7.5 Limitations

Several limitations affect the reliability and generalizability of this study, falling into conceptual and methodological categories.

Conceptually, two major concerns are related to the SM news and the corruption news salience variables. First, the SM news use question is a limited proxy for the underlying concept of corruption-content exposure. The theoretical framework expects SM news users to encounter more corruption-related content, but the variable measures self-reported SM use, not actual exposure to corruption information. This measurement is prone to confounding from unobserved respondent differences. One potential solution would be to employ APIs of SM platforms to more directly analyze the content[15]. A promising data collection setup is that of Gauthier et al. (2026) who use a Google Chrome extension to capture the exact content served to users and can therefore more plausibly measure informational exposure. Second, the ML4P data measures corruption salience in news coverage. The research design implies that this reflects the prominence of corruption information online as well. However, it does not measure this directly. While the outlets included in the ML4P dataset all have a major online presence, the decentralized nature of SM could by design serve very different realities to users. Ideally, a dedicated data source would monitor the salience of corruption information in Kenya's digital environment.

Methodologically, two concerns stand out. First, the research design does not allow for the identification of causality. There is no clear treatment variable that is subject to exogenous

[15] For the present study, this was not possible as TikTok's API only allows access to PhD researchers and above and X recently drastically reduced access to its API.

variation. The purely observational associations are limited in what they can say about how SM news use actually shapes corruption perceptions – the observed coefficients could reflect other (unobserved) changes in sampling or composition. Second, the salience–trend finding, while robust across specifications, rests on between-round variation across five data points. Corruption news salience is constant within each round, precluding any within-round identification strategy. The coefficient should therefore be interpreted as a well-documented descriptive pattern rather than a causal estimate. Nonetheless, the pattern is consistent, large in magnitude, and theoretically interpretable, making it a productive starting point for future research.

8 Conclusion

Understanding corruption perceptions is the first step to understanding corruption voting and political action. The information environment plays an important role in how these perceptions are formed, and the digital transformation of news consumption has reshaped this environment globally. This thesis examines how social media news consumption shapes corruption perceptions in Kenya, combining Afrobarometer data from 2014–2024 with corruption news salience from the ML4P project as a context measure.

The results show that Kenyans who regularly use social media for news consumption perceive higher levels of corruption. In times of high corruption salience in the news, all Kenyans – those who are active on social media and those who are not – regularly report that corruption is increasing less sharply but do not perceive lower corruption per se. If this reflects an accountability-signal mechanism, it suggests that Kenyans remain attentive to anti-corruption action. The design does not allow me to judge this interpretation against alternatives, but the pattern is consistent with the view that disclosure still carries signaling weight even in a high-corruption context.

By isolating the first stage of the corruption-voting chain (Vries & Solaz, 2017) – perception formation – this thesis offers a cleaner estimation strategy than designs that bundle information acquisition, blame attribution, and vote choice into a single outcome. This separation matters given the large gap between survey-experimental and observational estimates of corruption-information effects (Incerti, 2020). Empirically, the finding that higher corruption news salience predicts less negative trend perceptions runs partly against what the literature on media and corruption would predict. Interpreted through an accountability-signal lens, however, the pattern is consistent with the broader finding that citizens update their beliefs in response to corruption information (Arias et al., 2022; Chang et al., 2010; Ferraz & Finan, 2008). The difference being that here, the information is read as evidence of institutional response rather than institutional failure. The level-trend divergence is itself a contribution. It points to how much measurement choice shapes what we read out as corruption perception, and offers a productive starting point for future research.

On digital media's role as an information channel, the picture is mixed. On the one hand, levels of perceived corruption are associated with digital media use – though with the above-discussed caveats of low coefficient size and no claim of causality. This finding matches the expectations of digital media playing a distinct role in shaping political attitudes (Guriev et al., 2021). The hypothesized effects of an interaction between corruption salience and social media use as well as the hypothesis that the information value of social media would grow over time, however, did not find evidence in the data. More granular approaches, exploiting variation in the exact content and comparing different online platforms, could further shed light on these arguments.

As a single-case study, the findings have limited generalizability, but the underlying dynamics are not unique to Kenya. Kenya is one of the most digitally advanced countries in Sub-Saharan Africa and also stands out as one of the few – although imperfect – democracies in the region. Still, social media has expanded rapidly across Africa, and its effects on corruption perceptions are not limited to democracies. The present study further reinforces the importance of information and its low-barrier availability. Especially where information was previously scarce, social media's role as an alternative channel is essential. As the digital environment shifts toward interest-based recommendation (Törnberg & Rogers, 2026), understanding how algorithmic exposure shapes political beliefs becomes increasingly important.

The thesis opened with a quote by Hanifa Adan Safia, a protester at the June 2024 demonstrations. In her quote, she points out the contrast between an arrogant display of wealth and the visible deprivation of others – a reality Kenyans are confronted with daily, online and in person. While this first wave of protests falls just outside the period analyzed here, it underscore the relevance of what this thesis has documented: Perceptions of corruption and of the political environment more broadly are ultimately grounded in what people see – and can, under the right conditions, lay the groundwork for political change.

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Appendices

A Descriptive Statistics

Table A1: *Overview of Afrobarometer Survey Rounds Used in the Analysis*

Round	Fieldwork dates	N
5	November 4, 2011–November 29, 2012	2,400
6	November 12, 2014–December 5, 2014	2,397
7	September 13, 2016–October 8, 2016	1,599
8	August 28, 2019–October 1, 2019	2,400
9	November 12, 2021–November 30, 2021	2,400
10	April 10, 2024–May 3, 2024	2,400
Total		13,595

Note. N refers to the number of completed interviews. The total represents the pooled sample size across all six survey rounds.

Table A2: *Availability of Key Afrobarometer Measures Across Survey Rounds*

Measure	R5	R6	R7	R8	R9	R10
Corruption measures						
Perceived corruption battery	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Corruption trend		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Reporting corruption without fear			✓	✓	✓	✓
Digital media measures						
Internet news	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Social media news		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Internet use	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Phone internet access			✓	✓	✓	✓
Political posting on social media						✓

Note. Blank cells indicate that no directly comparable measure was included in that survey round.

Table A3: *Inclusion of Actors in the Corruption Perception Battery by Round*

Actor	R5	R6	R7	R8	R9	R10
Office of the presidency	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Members of parliament	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Government officials	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Local government or county assembly	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Police	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Judges and magistrates	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Tax officials	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓
Traditional leaders		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Religious leaders		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Office of the governor		✓	✓		✓	✓
Business executives		✓	✓		✓	✓
NGOs			✓		✓	✓
Military (KDF)		✓	✓			
Office of the prime minister	✓					
Members of the senate					✓	

Note. Table shows the inclusion of items for the question: "How many of the following people do you think are involved in corruption, or haven't you heard enough about them to say?" Respondents answer on a four-point scale: 0 ("None"), 1 ("Some of them"), 2 ("Most of them"), and 3 ("All of them"). The question on local government changed to County Assembly from Round 6 onward, with the full introduction of devolved government at the county level after the 2010 constitutional reform.

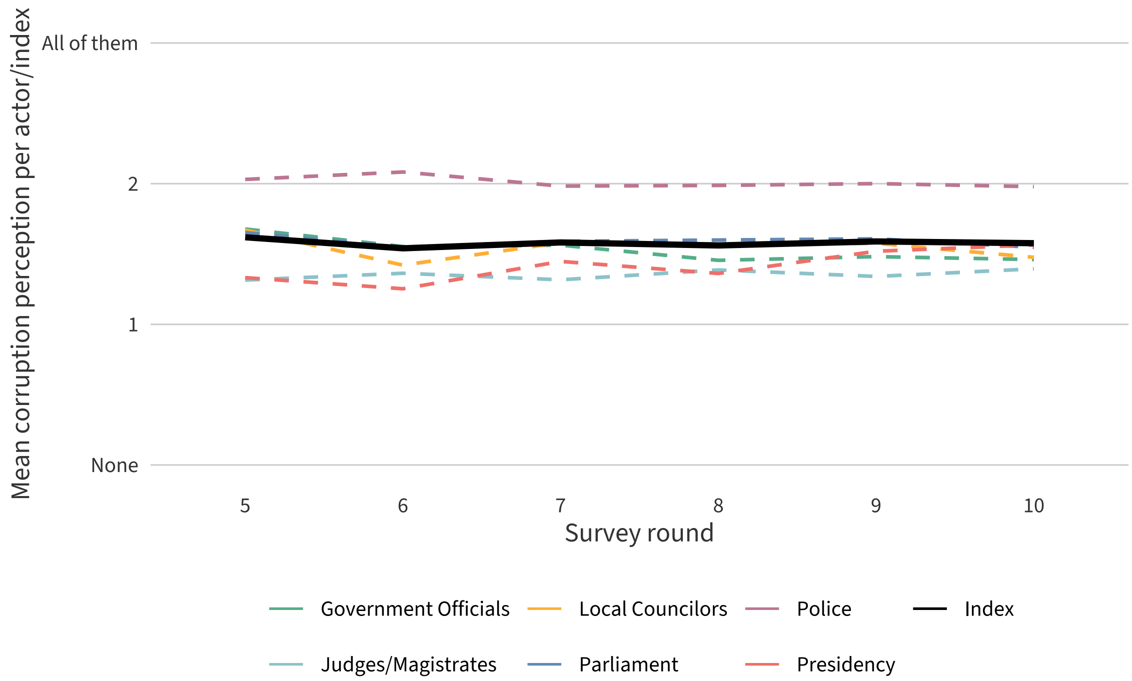

Figure A1: *Trends in Corruption Perception Across Political Actors.* Response options range from 0 ("None") to 3 ("All of them"). The index represents the average across all six actors.

Table A4: *Internal Consistency of Corruption Index*

Round	Alpha (α)	Omega Hierarchical (ω_h)	Omega Total (ω_t)
5	0.80	0.80	0.81
6	0.81	0.81	0.81
7	0.84	0.84	0.84
8	0.82	0.82	0.82
9	0.84	0.84	0.84
10	0.80	0.80	0.80
Pooled	0.81	0.82	0.82

Note. Estimates are based on the six core items present in all survey rounds.

Table A5: *Summary Statistics for the Main Corruption Perception Index*

Survey round	N	Mean	SD	Range
5	2,245	1.62	0.54	0–3
6	2,278	1.54	0.55	0–3
7	1,470	1.58	0.57	0–3
8	2,336	1.56	0.59	0–3
9	2,315	1.59	0.60	0–3
10	2,292	1.58	0.57	0–3
All rounds	12,936	1.58	0.57	0–3

Note. The table reports descriptive statistics for the main corruption perception index constructed from the six core items. The index is calculated as the row-wise mean of the included items and ranges from 0 (“None”) to 3 (“All of them”) N reports the number of respondents for whom the main corruption perception index could be calculated.

Table A6: *Item-level “Don’t know / haven’t heard enough” Responses*

Actor	R5	R6	R7	R8	R9	R10	Pooled
Government officials	6.42	4.76	7.07	4.04	4.42	5.79	5.32
Judges and magistrates	10.21	8.30	12.51	4.75	4.88	7.21	7.71
LG / CA	5.92	5.84	8.07	3.08	3.46	4.42	4.96
Members of parliament	6.79	5.34	8.13	3.08	4.12	5.46	5.33
Police	4.84	2.34	5.82	2.00	2.29	2.04	3.07
Office of the presidency	10.13	9.22	11.57	5.21	6.00	6.62	7.92

Note. Entries report the percentage of respondents who answered “don’t know” or “haven’t heard enough to say” for each corruption item before recoding special values to `NA`. The pooled column reports percentages across all rounds combined. LG/CA stands for “local government/county assembly”.

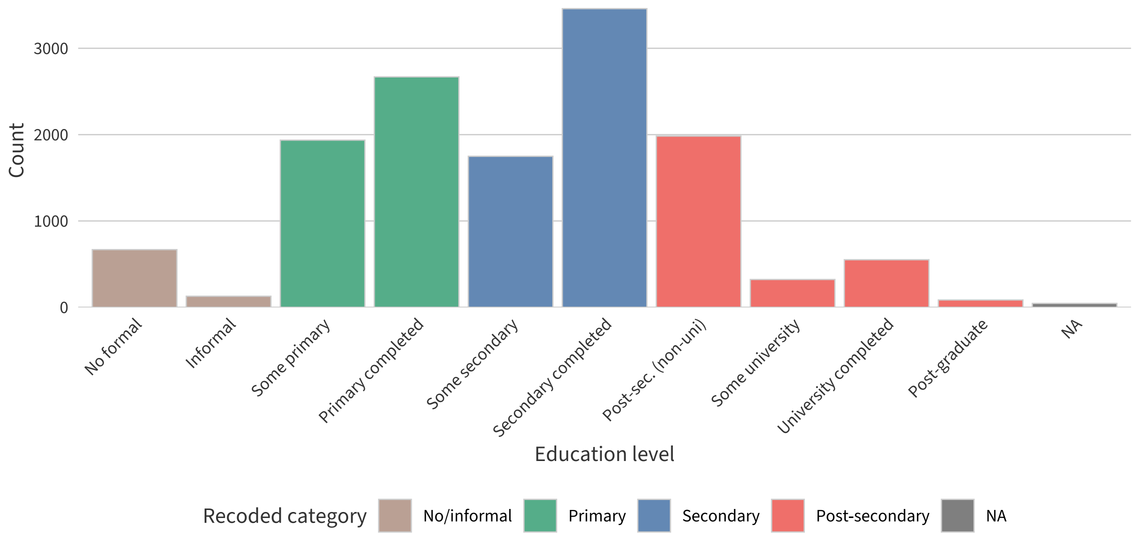

Figure A2: *Distribution of the Original Education Variable and Recoded Categories.* Bar colors indicate the four recoded groups used in the analysis: no or informal education (0–1), primary (2–3), secondary (4–5), and post-secondary (6–9).

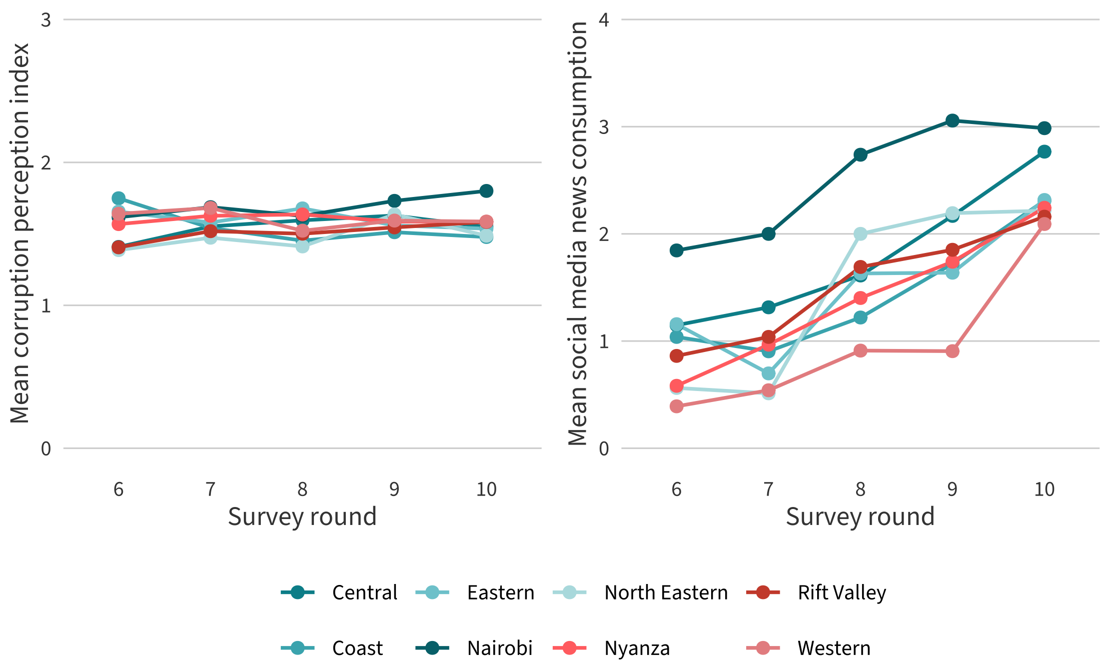

Figure A3: *Mean Corruption Perceptions and Social Media News Consumption by Province across Survey Rounds*. The left panel shows the mean corruption perception index (0–3) by province across survey rounds, and the right panel the mean frequency of social media news consumption (0–4).

B Robustness and Alternative Specifications

Weighted Regressions

Table B1: Information Hypothesis: Weighted Regressions

	Bivariate	Round FE	Controls + FE	Controls + Media
Social Media News (0–4)	0.012***	0.011***	0.009*	0.011*
	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.004)
Round 7		0.034†	0.022	0.020
		(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.020)
Round 8		0.015	-0.021	-0.024
		(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Round 9		0.043*	-0.009	-0.016
		(0.018)	(0.019)	(0.019)
Round 10		0.025	-0.030	-0.040†
		(0.019)	(0.020)	(0.020)
Age			0.003***	0.003***
			(0.000)	(0.000)
Education			0.058***	0.061***
			(0.008)	(0.009)
Urban			0.105***	0.108***
			(0.013)	(0.013)
Lived Poverty Index			0.096***	0.096***
			(0.008)	(0.008)
Radio News				-0.002
				(0.005)
Newspaper News				-0.012*
				(0.005)
TV News				0.001
				(0.004)
R2	0.002	0.002	0.034	0.035
R2 Adj.	0.001	0.002	0.033	0.034
Num.Obs.	10626	10626	10580	10559

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Models estimated with Afrobarometer within-EA survey weights.

Table B2: Responsiveness Baseline (Level Index): Weighted Regressions

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)			0.009*
			(0.004)
Corruption News Salience	0.718	-1.058	-1.379†
	(0.674)	(0.681)	(0.712)
Age		0.003***	0.003***
		(0.000)	(0.000)
Education		0.065***	0.061***
		(0.008)	(0.009)
Urban		0.110***	0.110***
		(0.012)	(0.013)
Lived Poverty Index		0.094***	0.094***
		(0.008)	(0.008)
Radio News			-0.001
			(0.005)
Newspaper News			-0.010*
			(0.005)
TV News			0.000
			(0.004)
R2	0.000	0.033	0.034
R2 Adj.	0.000	0.033	0.034
Num.Obs.	10691	10645	10559

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Models estimated with Afrobarometer within-EA survey weights.

Table B3: Responsiveness Baseline (Trend): Weighted Regressions

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)			0.028**
			(0.009)
Corruption News Salience	-7.648***	-10.937***	-11.529***
	(1.470)	(1.474)	(1.529)
Age		0.004***	0.005***
		(0.001)	(0.001)
Education		0.068***	0.063***
		(0.016)	(0.018)
Urban		0.091***	0.098***
		(0.027)	(0.028)
Lived Poverty Index		0.193***	0.188***
		(0.015)	(0.016)
Radio News			-0.000
			(0.010)
Newspaper News			-0.023*
			(0.011)
TV News			-0.015†
			(0.009)
R2	0.003	0.023	0.024
R2 Adj.	0.003	0.022	0.023
Num.Obs.	10913	10868	10780

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Models estimated with Afrobarometer within-EA survey weights.

Alternative Dependent Variables

Table B4: Information Hypothesis: Reduced Four-Item Corruption Index

	Bivariate	Round FE	Controls + FE	Controls + Media
Social Media News (0–4)	0.012***	0.010**	0.009*	0.010*
	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.004)
Round 7		0.098***	0.085***	0.084***
		(0.021)	(0.021)	(0.021)
Round 8		0.045*	0.006	0.005
		(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Round 9		0.090***	0.035†	0.032
		(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.020)
Round 10		0.051**	-0.016	-0.024
		(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.020)
Age			0.003***	0.003***
			(0.000)	(0.000)
Education			0.054***	0.056***
			(0.009)	(0.009)
Urban			0.105***	0.105***
			(0.013)	(0.013)
Lived Poverty Index			0.106***	0.105***
			(0.008)	(0.008)
Radio News				-0.009
				(0.005)
Newspaper News				-0.006
				(0.005)
TV News				0.000
				(0.004)
R2	0.001	0.004	0.033	0.034
R2 Adj.	0.001	0.004	0.032	0.032
Num.Obs.	10528	10528	10484	10464

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$
HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.
DV is the reduced four-item corruption perception index
(excludes police and judges/magistrates).

Table B5: Information Hypothesis: Corruption Trend as DV

	Bivariate	Round FE	Controls + FE	Controls + Media
Social Media News (0–4)	-0.001	-0.001	0.012	0.020*
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.008)	(0.009)
Round 7		0.127**	0.105**	0.101*
		(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)
Round 8		-0.048	-0.117**	-0.112**
		(0.036)	(0.037)	(0.037)
Round 9		0.378***	0.275***	0.275***
		(0.034)	(0.035)	(0.036)
Round 10		-0.072†	-0.191***	-0.194***
		(0.037)	(0.038)	(0.039)
Age			0.004***	0.004***
			(0.001)	(0.001)
Education			0.049**	0.058***
			(0.016)	(0.017)
Urban			0.086***	0.102***
			(0.025)	(0.026)
Lived Poverty Index			0.181***	0.175***
			(0.014)	(0.014)
Radio News				-0.002
				(0.009)
Newspaper News				-0.013
				(0.010)
TV News				-0.018*
				(0.008)
R2	0.000	0.020	0.036	0.037
R2 Adj.	-0.000	0.019	0.036	0.036
Num.Obs.	10847	10847	10802	10780

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$
HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.
DV is the perceived corruption trend
(1 = decreased a lot, 5 = increased a lot).

Alternative Independent Variable

Table B6: Information Hypothesis: Binary Social Media News Measure

	Bivariate	Round FE	Controls + FE	Controls + Media
Social Media News (binary)	0.030**	0.026*	0.016	0.019
	(0.011)	(0.012)	(0.014)	(0.015)
Round 7		0.044*	0.031†	0.030
		(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.019)
Round 8		0.020	-0.016	-0.018
		(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Round 9		0.045**	-0.006	-0.012
		(0.017)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Round 10		0.029†	-0.035*	-0.044*
		(0.017)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Age			0.003***	0.003***
			(0.000)	(0.000)
Education			0.058***	0.060***
			(0.008)	(0.008)
Urban			0.103***	0.103***
			(0.012)	(0.012)
Lived Poverty Index			0.098***	0.098***
			(0.008)	(0.008)
Radio News				-0.004
				(0.005)
Newspaper News				-0.008†
				(0.005)
TV News				0.003
				(0.004)
R2	0.001	0.001	0.033	0.034
R2 Adj.	0.001	0.001	0.032	0.032
Num.Obs.	10626	10626	10580	10559

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$
HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.
IV is the binary SM news measure (0 = non-regular user, 1 = regular user).

Province Fixed Effects

Table B7: Information Hypothesis: Province Fixed Effects and Clustered SEs

	Main (HC2)	Province FE	Clustered SE	FE + Clustered
Social Media News (0–4)	0.007†	0.008*	0.007**	0.008***
	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.003)	(0.002)
Round 7	0.031	0.030	0.031	0.030
	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.037)	(0.037)
Round 8	-0.018	-0.017	-0.018	-0.017
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.044)	(0.045)
Round 9	-0.009	-0.008	-0.009	-0.008
	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.052)	(0.053)
Round 10	-0.039*	-0.035†	-0.039	-0.035
	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.058)	(0.059)
Age	0.003***	0.002***	0.003***	0.002***
	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.000)
Education	0.055***	0.050***	0.055***	0.050***
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.011)	(0.010)
Urban	0.102***	0.096***	0.102***	0.096***
	(0.012)	(0.013)	(0.030)	(0.027)
Lived Poverty Index	0.099***	0.099***	0.099***	0.099***
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.008)
R2	0.033	0.039	0.033	0.039
R2 Adj.	0.032	0.037	0.032	0.037
Num.Obs.	10580	10580	10580	10580

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Models (1)–(2) use HC2 robust SEs; models (3)–(4) use CR2 province-clustered SEs.

Province dummies suppressed for readability.

Alternate Corruption News Salience Windows

Table B8: Responsiveness Baseline (Level Index): 1-Month Salience Window

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)			0.007†
			(0.004)
Corruption News Salience (1m)	1.659*	-1.412†	-2.069*
	(0.725)	(0.740)	(0.816)
Age		0.002***	0.003***
		(0.000)	(0.000)
Education		0.061***	0.058***
		(0.007)	(0.008)
Urban		0.104***	0.103***
		(0.012)	(0.012)
Lived Poverty Index		0.096***	0.097***
		(0.007)	(0.008)
Radio News			-0.003
			(0.005)
Newspaper News			-0.009†
			(0.005)
TV News			0.002
			(0.004)
R2	0.000	0.032	0.033
R2 Adj.	0.000	0.032	0.032
Num.Obs.	10691	10645	10559

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Salience measured as 1-month average preceding each survey round.

Table B9: Responsiveness Interaction (Level Index): 1-Month Salience Window

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)	0.023**	0.016†	0.020*
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.009)
Corruption News Salience (1m)	2.210*	-0.948	-1.112
	(1.012)	(1.028)	(1.041)
Salience (1m) $\times$ SM News	-0.711†	-0.521	-0.671
	(0.414)	(0.408)	(0.414)
Age		0.003***	0.003***
		(0.000)	(0.000)
Education		0.055***	0.058***
		(0.008)	(0.008)
Urban		0.102***	0.103***
		(0.012)	(0.012)
Lived Poverty Index		0.098***	0.097***
		(0.008)	(0.008)
Radio News			-0.004
			(0.005)
Newspaper News			-0.010*
			(0.005)
TV News			0.002
			(0.004)
R2	0.002	0.033	0.033
R2 Adj.	0.001	0.032	0.032
Num.Obs.	10626	10580	10559

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$
HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.
Salience measured as 1-month average preceding each survey round.

Table B10: Responsiveness Baseline (Trend): 1-Month Salience Window

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)			0.024**
			(0.009)
Corruption News Salience (1m)	-1.629	-6.721***	-7.976***
	(1.579)	(1.594)	(1.736)
Age		0.004***	0.004***
		(0.001)	(0.001)
Education		0.061***	0.058***
		(0.015)	(0.017)
Urban		0.085***	0.090***
		(0.025)	(0.026)
Lived Poverty Index		0.192***	0.189***
		(0.014)	(0.014)
Radio News			0.003
			(0.009)
Newspaper News			-0.021*
			(0.010)
TV News			-0.012
			(0.008)
R2	0.000	0.019	0.020
R2 Adj.	0.000	0.019	0.019
Num.Obs.	10913	10868	10780

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Salience measured as 1-month average preceding each survey round.

Table B11: Responsiveness Baseline (Level Index): 12-Month Salience Window

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)			0.005
			(0.004)
Corruption News Salience (12m)	0.850	-0.271	-0.283
	(0.617)	(0.614)	(0.626)
Age		0.002***	0.003***
		(0.000)	(0.000)
Education		0.060***	0.057***
		(0.007)	(0.008)
Urban		0.104***	0.104***
		(0.012)	(0.012)
Lived Poverty Index		0.094***	0.094***
		(0.007)	(0.007)
Radio News			-0.003
			(0.005)
Newspaper News			-0.006
			(0.005)
TV News			0.001
			(0.004)
R2	0.000	0.032	0.032
R2 Adj.	0.000	0.031	0.032
Num.Obs.	10691	10645	10559

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Salience measured as 12-month average preceding each survey round.

Table B12: Responsiveness Interaction (Level Index): 12-Month Salience Window

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)	0.007	-0.002	-0.000
	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.007)
Corruption News Salience (12m)	0.505	-0.654	-0.637
	(0.791)	(0.787)	(0.789)
Salience (12m) $\times$ SM News	0.188	0.311	0.277
	(0.355)	(0.350)	(0.351)
Age		0.003***	0.003***
		(0.000)	(0.000)
Education		0.055***	0.057***
		(0.008)	(0.008)
Urban		0.103***	0.104***
		(0.012)	(0.012)
Lived Poverty Index		0.094***	0.094***
		(0.007)	(0.007)
Radio News			-0.002
			(0.005)
Newspaper News			-0.006
			(0.005)
TV News			0.001
			(0.004)
R2	0.001	0.032	0.032
R2 Adj.	0.001	0.031	0.032
Num.Obs.	10626	10580	10559

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Salience measured as 12-month average preceding each survey round.

Table B13: Responsiveness Baseline (Trend): 12-Month Salience Window

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)			0.018*
			(0.008)
Corruption News Salience (12m)	-5.008***	-6.863***	-6.849***
	(1.324)	(1.313)	(1.335)
Age		0.004***	0.004***
		(0.001)	(0.001)
Education		0.057***	0.057***
		(0.015)	(0.017)
Urban		0.083***	0.092***
		(0.025)	(0.026)
Lived Poverty Index		0.186***	0.181***
		(0.014)	(0.014)
Radio News			0.005
			(0.009)
Newspaper News			-0.015
			(0.010)
TV News			-0.016†
			(0.008)
R2	0.001	0.020	0.020
R2 Adj.	0.001	0.019	0.019
Num.Obs.	10913	10868	10780

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Salience measured as 12-month average preceding each survey round.

Sensitivity to Round 9 Exclusion

Table B14: Responsiveness Baseline (Trend): Excluding Round 9

	Bivariate	Controls	Media
Social Media News (0–4)			0.016
			(0.010)
Corruption News Salience	-3.940**	-7.433***	-7.158***
	(1.379)	(1.394)	(1.502)
Age		0.003***	0.004***
		(0.001)	(0.001)
Education		0.041*	0.041*
		(0.017)	(0.019)
Urban		0.112***	0.123***
		(0.028)	(0.030)
Lived Poverty Index		0.182***	0.176***
		(0.016)	(0.017)
Radio News			0.002
			(0.011)
Newspaper News			-0.003
			(0.011)
TV News			-0.024**
			(0.009)
R2	0.001	0.018	0.018
R2 Adj.	0.001	0.017	0.017
Num.Obs.	8543	8502	8434

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses.

Round 9 (November 2021) excluded as a sensitivity check on the salience–trend finding.

Corruption Salience Trend Interaction

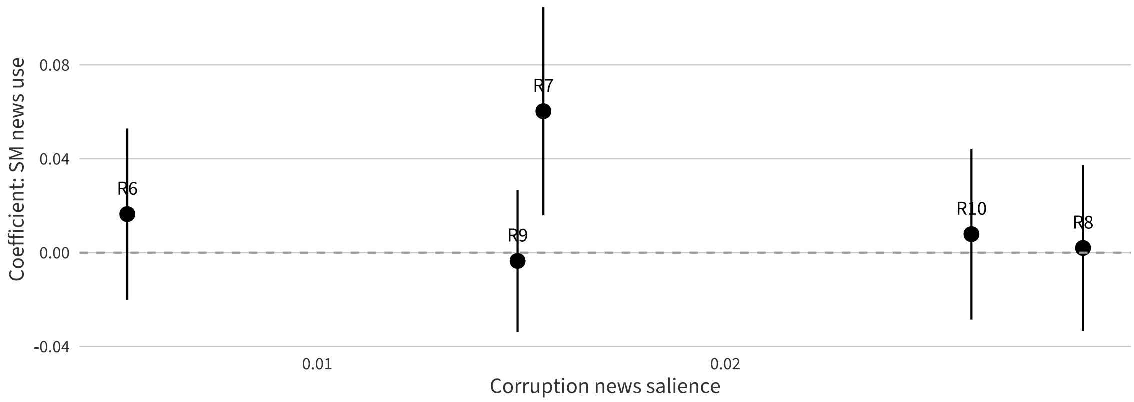

Figure B1: *Round-Specific SMN Coefficients by Corruption News Salience*. Round-specific estimates of the SM news coefficient on the corruption trend variable, plotted against the three-month average of corruption news salience preceding each survey round. HC2 robust standard errors. 95% CIs.

C Descriptive Exploratory Analysis

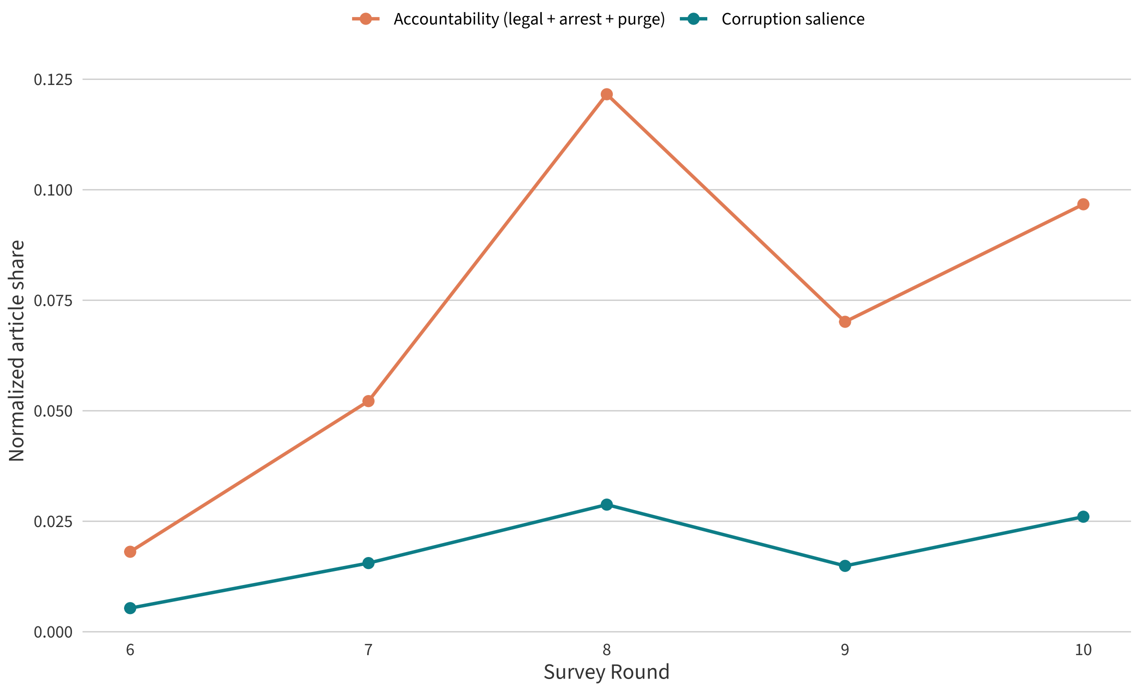

Figure C1: *ML4P Corruption and Accountability Salience Development.* Development of the normalized corruption salience measure used in the analysis against the sum of the normalized salience of arrest, legal action, and purge measures.